Skeletor

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Skeletor

by PenNameSmith

Summary

A series of short, feel-good, zero-stakes stories set after the finale.

Entrapta needs Hordak's help with a familiar-seeming robot. Wrong Hordak hosts a therapy group. Catra and Adora are trying their best. Scorpia and Perfuma are figuring things out. Double Trouble is definitely hiding somewhere. Glimmer and Bow are fashionably late. Everyone gets to be friends and talk about their feelings.

Come in, you royal boob! Myaah!

Notes

This started out being written around the joke "What if Skeletor entered the SPoP universe as a harmless bot who speaks entirely in 80s Skeletor quotes?" and quickly became a series of short stories about the Ex-Horde crew going to therapy together. I hope you enjoy them.

Skeletor

Hordak set down his soldering iron and chanced a look out the window of Entrapta's Bright Moon workshop. The wind had grown chilly outside, but citizens in heavy coats were still hanging lights and bits of shiny paper on every available surface. This had been going on for over an hour now.

"Tell me, Entrapta," Hordak said, resting his chin on steepled fingers. "Why is *winter* a cause for celebration in these parts?"

Entrapta, seated at the workbench next to him, looked up from her welding. "Adora's birthday is coming up! Queen Glimmer declared it a national holiday. And the decorations were Catra's idea." She produced a sprig of holly and held it out with one ponytail. "You can help put some up if you want!"

Hordak hesitated. "I… no *thank* you?" he ventured, trying out his newest social skill.

"That's what I said you'd say when Bow asked me!" Entrapta stuffed the holly back into one of her many pockets. "Oh, but there is something else you can help me with! Here, meet Skeletor!"

Hordak started. "Meet *who?*" he asked, apprehensively.

"It's what I nicknamed my new project!" Entrapta jumped up and scuttled to a far corner of the workshop. With a flourish, she yanked a cloth off of something slouched between piles of spare parts.

Sitting in a chair under the cloth was one of Horde Prime's old drone robots. Entrapta had stripped the armor away from its limbs and face, so that now it looked like a barrel-chested stick figure. In place of the angular faceplate there was something that resembled a human skull with a goofy frown. Entrapta flipped a switch and it shuddered to life.

“I tried to make it so he could talk. But the pitch for the voice box is all messed up, so — ”

“Myaah!” the robot cried suddenly in a nasal tone, before raising both fists in a gesture of impotent frustration.

“...So he keeps doing that.”

“I see.” Hordak leaned over to look more closely at the robot. “And was there a… *purpose* for this exercise?”

Entrapta shrugged her hair. “Well, Wrong Hordak said he wanted an assistant for his clone therapy group, and I thought, hey! I’ve got a spare robot you can use! Can you believe it?”

Hordak permitted himself a smile. “I have no doubt that is *exactly* how events transpired, my dear.” He turned his attention back to the robot. “Hello, ‘Skeletor.’”

“You’re a boob!” the robot replied. It chuckled awkwardly. “Meheheheh.”

“Okay, so the personality needs some work too,” Entrapta said. “But maybe you could help with that, Hordak! You can be like Skeletor’s mentor!”

“I don’t know about *that,*” Hordak said, uncertainly.

“I could write a *book* about what you don’t know!” the robot piped up. “Meheheheheh.”

Hordak blinked. “How droll. Well, I’m sure that with *considerable* work we’ll be able to repair it together.”

“No time for that!” Entrapta chirped. “I promised Wrong Hordak you’d drop him off in twenty minutes. You’re going to have so much fun!”

“You *what?* Why am I meant to deliver this ridiculous thing?”

Hordak shot his eyes back to Entrapta. In the time since he'd looked away she had donned a winter coat and hefted two small fir trees in her hair.

"Because I told Bow I'd help with the birthday decorations after I said you'd say you didn't want to!" Entrapta had a wide smile on. "I'll see you later tonight Hordak, your imperfections make you beautiful, you're gonna do great, *bye-eee!*" she called out in one manic breath as she bustled out the door.

Hordak had a finger poised in the air and had opened his mouth to say something, but the door was already shut. He lowered his hand and pursed his lips.

"Myaah!" Skeletor said, and shook his fists again.

Wrong Hordak stood at the front of a room filled with about two dozen near-identical clones, leading breathing exercises.

"That is correct, brothers! Breathe *in* positivity! Breathe *out* the insidious deceptions of Horde Prime!"

Hordak watched this from the hall doorway while Skeletor wobbled behind him, leaning on a discarded curtain rod like a walking staff. Just as he decided to retreat back to the workshop, Wrong Hordak noticed him and ushered them in, smiling hugely.

"Brother Hordak! It is an honor! Welcome!" Wrong Hordak turned his attention to the clones, who were all sitting cross-legged on the floor. "Brothers, this is Hordak! He was the first of us to name himself and resist the cruel lies of Horde Prime!"

"Glory to Hordak!" one of the clones cried cheerfully. "Hordak knows all!"

"No, no," Wrong Hordak corrected, gently. "Hordak is wise and handsome, but he does *not* know all, for *none* of us know all."

“Glory to Hordak, who knows *some* things!” the clone tried again. Wrong Hordak nodded in approval, and the others cheered.

Coming further into the room, Hordak realized that not all of the attendees were clones. Sitting in a row among their ranks were a towering scorpion woman, a flowered princess, She-Ra’s human host, and a cat.

“Fools!” Skeletor cackled, and Hordak wished very much that he could fall down a trapdoor into a bottomless abyss.

This was not to be. “Ooh! Ooh! Hordak!” Scorpia called out, waving her claw in the air. “Hey, Hordak! It’s us! Over here! Come sit with us!”

“Scorpia. Princess Perfuma. Adora. Adora’s girlfriend,” Hordak greeted as he moved towards them. “And what brings you to this fine meeting place today?”

“Noble Perfuma is giving a guest lesson on meditation today!” Wrong Hordak said, sparkling in delight.

“Perfuma invited me!” Scorpia added.

“I actually come here every week,” Adora admitted. “I find Wrong Hordak’s self care tips to be helpful, and stuff.”

“I am here under *duress*,” Catra grumbled, casting a look at Adora. “And because you made the *cute face* when you asked me.” She looked back at Hordak. “So why are *you* here?”

“I — ” Hordak started.

“Brother Hordak has brought the liberator Entrapta’s new helper for us!” Wrong Hordak interrupted. He gestured to Skeletor.

“You’re all a bunch of bumbling boobs!” Skeletor said.

Hordak sighed. This was *not* the time for a skeleton to be causing civil unrest. He put a hand on the robot’s shoulder and guided

them both into a sitting position.

“I will not have you disrupt my brother’s work like this,” Hordak said firmly. “Now then. Entrapta commanded us to... *have fun*, and that is what we shall do.”

“You mean get in fights?” Skeletor asked.

“No, fun.”

“Fights *are* fun,” Skeletor whined. “I like fights.”

Hordak ran a hand through his hair and took several deep breaths while counting to ten. “Princess Perfuma, I believe it would be beneficial if you began your meditation instruction now,” he said.

One hour later, a peaceful calm had descended across the entire room. Even Skeletor’s frown seemed more relaxed. Clones stood up and mingled as they passed out of the room in small groups. Scorpia left hand in claw with Perfuma while Adora and Catra jogged down the hallway toward a waving Glimmer and Bow.

“I don’t know what’s happening to me,” Skeletor complained. “I don’t like to feel good! I like to feel evil!”

“Thank you for visiting us today, brother!” Wrong Hordak said, shaking Hordak’s hand effusively. “You are welcome to return to this place whenever you wish!”

“I may have to,” Hordak replied, while looking at Skeletor. The robot was now covering its face and moaning quietly. “If only to keep our boneheaded friend here in line.”

The significance of what he said did not strike him until some time after that.

Later, in the room that they shared, Hordak looked Entrapta in the eyes and asked, “Did you… *engineer* this sequence of events?”

“Of course not! It would take some kind of mad genius schemer person to do something like that,” Entrapta deflected. “And anyway, I heard you did great at group today. I want to come with next time!”

She hugged her lab partner closer, with her hands and her hair. “Oh, and happy She-Ra Day.”

“Happy She-Ra Day,” Hordak relented.

“Myaah!” said Skeletor.

Welcome Back, Skeletor

Chapter Summary

> Hordak wants to talk to Catra about something. She-Ra does battle with Skeletor.

Another day, another Ex-Horde Therapy Group meeting.

Today the clones were helping to arrange a large circle of comfortable chairs, under Wrong Hordak's enthusiastic direction. Perfuma, whose meditation lesson the previous week had proven popular enough to warrant an encore, centered herself while Scorpia did her best to shuffle a deck of yoga cards by her side. More clones trickled in through the hallway door every few minutes.

Catra watched this from her vantage point in the back of the room, where she was helping to set up the snack table. Beside her, Entrapta's latest pet project - a reprogrammed Horde drone she'd nicknamed 'Skeletor' - set out more food while making various nasal utterances.

"Meheheh. You've done your job well, Catra!" Skeletor declared, surveying her work. Suddenly he snapped to attention. "Gah! It's that muscle-bound female, She-Ra!"

Catra followed his gaze to the other end of the narrow table, where Adora had claimed an entire tray of cheese cubes for herself and was now eating them by the handful. At Skeletor's approach she made a small sound of panic and hurried away toward the circle of chairs, hunched protectively over her plate.

A giggle escaped from Catra and she turned away from the scene, only to be met by an enormous looming shadow looking down at her.

"Oh! Hordak!" Her tail puffed and she tried, unsuccessfully, to hide it under the tablecloth. "Didn't see you there, buddy. You, uh,

want some honeydew?" She held the plate up like a shield.

Hordak accepted a piece of the offered fruit and regarded her mildly. "Thank you. I hope Skeletor isn't bothering you too much?"

Catra shrugged. "Nah. His laugh is weird and he keeps calling Melog 'Clawdeen,' but he's harmless enough."

"You should also avoid his doomberry pies," Hordak advised, casting an eye toward the food. "I am… not displeased to see you here today, you know. I was uncertain if you would return after your first visit."

"I could say the same about you." Catra looked back towards the chairs, where Skeletor and Adora's disagreement over the cheese plate was heating up. Entrapta had appeared between them and was holding the two warring parties apart with her hands, while her hair fidgeted with Skeletor's circuitry and snuck bites of cheese. "I guess we both have our, uh, significant princesses to blame for that. Plus, it's actually kind of nice to talk about stuff with people who get it."

"Indeed," Hordak agreed, looking in Entrapta's direction. "Also, I… had another motive in seeking you out today. I wish to apologize to you. Catra."

He said her name awkwardly - the first time he'd spoken it aloud since their imprisonment on Prime's ship - and Catra felt her bearings bouncing away.

"Um. *You* want to apologize to *me?* Did you forget about, y'know, the whole Beast Island thing?"

"No," Hordak growled, and for a moment his eyes grew sharper before softening again. "But nevertheless. I was a poor leader. And I caused you pain. And I am sorry for that."

Catra raised her eyebrows, then realized that he was reading off a piece of folded paper. "Did somebody put you up to this?"

Hordak huffed. “Hardly. Princess Perfuma *merely* suggested that it might behoove me to admit my wrongs and make amends with those I have harmed.” He looked away and shuffled his feet. “Scorpia may have helped somewhat with the wording.”

“No offense, but if that’s the road you wanna go down, you’re going to have a lot of amending to do.”

Hordak nodded. “Yes, well. It seemed as good a place as any to start.” He pocketed his paper. “The Princess Alliance has seen fit to forgive us our past lives in the Horde, and it would be disrespectful if I did not attempt to live up to that.”

Catra chuckled. “Hordak, the Alliance forgave us because nobody was in the mood to start a war with Dryl, Plumeria, and She-Ra at the same time.” She caught his expression. “But you’re right. So, uh, thanks. I’m sorry too. For everything. For whatever that means.”

“More than you may realize,” Hordak said, smiling softly. He glanced at something past her shoulder. “Excuse me. This may require my assistance.”

Hordak hurried off in the direction of Entrapta and Skeletor. The robot was now being held aloft in the scientist’s hair, limbs flailing wildly. He shook his fists.

“Dolts! Halfwits! Bunglers!” Skeletor cried.

“Now come on Skeletor, play nice!” Entrapta cajoled.

“I am *not* nice!” Skeletor shot back. “Blast that She-Ra! Always meddling! Myaah!”

Hordak reached them and began to gently extricate the peeved robot from his partner’s plumes of hair. Catra watched, smiling in spite of herself, until something blonde popped up into her field of vision and she started back with a yelp.

“Hey Cathra!” Adora said, mouth full. “You want thome cheethe?” She held out the cheese plate. There were one and a half cubes remaining, along with some crumbs.

“I’m good, thanks,” Catra replied, regaining her calm, and her smile. She took the plate from Adora and replaced it with one of her hands. “So, I think Hordak just tried to be nice to me?”

“Oh, yeah, I totally put him up to it,” Adora said, flicking a cheese crumb off her shoulder. “I think he went to Perfuma and Scorpia for extra advice though. Did it go okay? He’s really trying, I swear.”

Something in Catra’s chest melted, and she laughed heartily. “C’mon, Adora. Let’s go join the circle before all the good seats are taken.”

Of course, all the good seats were taken. Catra and Adora wound up sitting next to Skeletor, who was frowning with his arms crossed beside Hordak.

“Behave,” Hordak hissed, while Entrapta hung off the side of her chair to make eyes at him.

“You miserable excuse for a villain,” Skeletor muttered. But he behaved.

“Welcome, everyone!” Wrong Hordak chimed from the center of the circle. “Who is ready to develop coping strategies for the processing of traumatic experiences?”

Catra and Hordak shared a sidelong glance. They were, perhaps, more ready than they realized.

“Myaah!” Skeletor said, again.

My Friend, My Skeletor

Chapter Summary

> Adora and Hordak talk over coffee. Skeletor has a pleasant day.

Chattering excitedly about near-death experiences, the last of the clones strolled out of the hallway door at the end of another Ex-Horde Therapy Group session. Wrong Hordak watched them all go and waved cheerfully.

"I am *so sorry* about that," Perfuma groaned, next to him. She was covered in twigs, moss, and mud, and leaned exhaustedly on Scorpia's arm. "I didn't realize the Whispering Woods would provide quite so... *hostile* an environment for a walking meditation. Or that so many of the brothers would wander away from the group. *Repeatedly*. No matter *how* many times I reminded them that they could have become emotionally dysregulated, or eaten."

"Nonsense, noble Perfuma!" Wrong Hordak reassured her, sparkling happily. "We have learned *much* today about the value of understanding our responses to uncomfortable feelings, and also monsters."

"And Adora got everyone back just fine!" Scorpia added, patting Perfuma's head. "I mean, I think she did? I hope she did. I didn't exactly count. I'm *pretty sure* we got them all. Wrong Hordak?"

While Wrong Hordak counted carefully on his fingers, Adora wrapped up leftovers from the snack table. She, too, was covered in forest detritus, and still felt some of the lightheadedness that came after turning back from She-Ra. It had been an *eventful* day, to say the least. Putting away the room alongside her were Catra, Hordak, Entrapta, and 'Skeletor,' a spindly former Horde drone Entrapta was currently refurbishing. So far the results had been mixed.

“Idiots! Foolish mortals! If I’m not there, nothing is done right!” Skeletor whined, as he stacked chairs. “Myaah!”

Adora snorted, and idly picked at some of the leftover food. Her eyes flitted to where Catra was chatting shyly with an exuberant Entrapta, and she felt her heart swell. Despite the disarray, her world was healing.

“Hey Adora!” Catra called, looking her way suddenly. “I’ve gotta, uh, talk to Entrapta about something real quick. Right outside. We’ll be back in a minute, okay?”

Adora flashed a thumbs up as she chewed her way through some stale bagels. While Catra ushered Entrapta into the hallway, Hordak glanced in Adora’s direction and caught her eye. He left Skeletor with a broom and dustpan and approached her at the table.

“Your bravery and strength were most impressive today,” Hordak commented, pouring himself a cup of something hot from a copper carafe. Despite his looming stature, he seemed smaller and humbler in Adora’s presence. “We are… indebted, once again, to your kindness and protection. Perhaps you should, as the people of this planet say, take it easy for a moment.” He gestured to a free chair and offered a second cup of the drink he’d gotten himself. Adora accepted both and plopped down with a relieved sigh.

“Thanks. Today was an adventure all right,” Adora agreed, slouching in her seat. She sniffed at the dark, steaming liquid in her cup. “What *is* this stuff, anyway?”

“It is of my own invention,” Hordak said, with a hint of pride. He sat in another chair next to her. “The distilled essence of roasted coffee plant seeds. It contains restorative properties. The taste is naturally bitter, but you may add sugar if you wish.”

“Uh-huh, uh-huh,” Adora nodded, emptying most of the provided container of sweetener into her cup. Her sword flashed, and then

she was stirring the drink with a tiny golden spoon. "You weren't half bad today either, you know. I liked what you said about learning from failures."

"Mm."

An awkward silence stretched between them for several seconds. Adora scratched her head and a few leaves fell to the floor.

"You know, I'm proud of you."

It was Adora who said it. Hordak looked at her in surprise, but she kept going before he could say anything.

"I know what it's like to start a whole new life after only knowing the Horde. And what it's like to not be trusted at first." She paused, considering this. "I mean, I know it's *kind of* different since I'm She-Ra and everyone was cool with me after like a day, and *you're* the leader of the whole Etherian Horde and got brainwashed by Prime and some people still despise you even after you rebuilt Salineas and cleaned up Beast Island, and…"

She trailed off. Hordak's expression was impassive.

"Uh, but I'm getting off track. My point is, it's hard to keep doing the right thing after pain like that. And you are. Um, doing. The right thing, I mean." Flustered, Adora took a generous gulp of her drink. Her eyebrows shot up and her pupils dilated by several centimeters. "Oh. Wow. Wow. This is… wow. You want to go for a run? I feel like I could go for a run all of a sudden."

Hordak found his face softening. "I believe I understand what you are trying to say."

Adora, caffeinated, was not listening. "I mean, look at this guy!" She gestured vaguely at Skeletor. "He's ridiculous!"

"Behold my mystic cage of bones!" Skeletor cackled, as he emptied his dustpan into a trash bin.

“Most people would have thrown that thing out in the garbage,” Adora went on, rapidly tapping her feet.

“Entrapta did not,” Hordak countered, smiling.

“But you just… talk to it!” Adora threw her hands up, spilling some of her coffee. Skeletor saw the new mess and groaned in annoyance, fetching a mop. “You talk to it, and you’re patient with it, and you reason with it,” Adora said. “Even when it’s not being reasonable.”

“Mehehehehehehe! Now we’re playing in *my* dimension! See if you can stand up to my *stun-ray!*” Skeletor cried, mopping the floor.

“The mending process does not always make a great deal of sense,” Hordak conceded. “But we must be brave.”

“Speaking of,” Adora abruptly cut in. She took another huge swig of her drink. “You remember that *thing* I asked you about the other day? When Catra wasn’t here?”

Hordak quirked a brow. “I recall.”

“Good, because I’ve got blueprints.” Adora pulled a stack of scribbled-on paper napkins from her pocket. She held them up for Hordak. “Do you think you can do it?”

Hordak plucked a napkin from the stack and studied it. “Yes. This should be well within my scientific capabilities. I will contact you when construction is complete.” He hesitated. “Thank you for… trusting me, Adora. You are… an admirable role model.”

Adora smiled back.

“I’ve done it! I’ve triumphed at last!” Skeletor crowed as he finished cleaning.

Catra came back into the room at that moment, trailing an excitedly chattering Entrapta. When she saw Adora, her eyes bugged and she clamped a hand over the scientist’s mouth.

“That’s right, Entrapta!” Catra said, very loudly. “Science *is* very scientific! I couldn’t agree more!” She paused, casting her eyes back and forth. “And. Thank you for talking to me about, um… science. I respect your interest in this topic, because we are friends.”

Catra coughed.

“Aw, thanks,” Entrapta beamed, giving Catra a light pat on the head. “Hordak! I’ve got *lots* of new ideas for experiments after today! Listen to this!”

She and Hordak immediately fell into a world of their own, filled with trajectories and equilibriums. Adora smiled fondly at the pair and stood shakily to her feet, accepting a helping hand from Catra. She wasn’t sure if her heartbeat was racing because of the coffee, or because of the closeness of Catra’s face. But she felt fantastic.

Later, in their laboratory, Hordak eyed Entrapta over a paper napkin schematic. “It may amuse you to know the favor Adora asked of me today,” he began.

“Guess what Catra wants me to build?” Entrapta blurted out at the same time.

“She needs me to make her a ring,” they both finished together.

There was silence. The two mad scientists gaped at each other for a moment, and then the lab was filled with the ringing sound of their guffaws.

“Can we observe the reaction?” Entrapta squealed. “*Please?*”

“That would be rude, my dear.”

“Okay, okay,” she pouted. “But. Are we going to tell them?”

“Of course not! That would corrupt the data.”

Entrapta clapped happily. “Oh, this is going to be so much *fun!* Do you think we should make them matching, like ours?” She tapped at a purple First Ones crystal that hung on a pendant around her neck, the twin to Hordak’s own. “Ooh! Or what if we made ones that turn into robots?”

Hordak, who still felt laughter bubbling up from inside him, leaned in to be closer to his imperfect, beautiful partner. His imagination burned. They had much to scheme.

“Ahh,” said Skeletor. “I can’t remember when I’ve had a more pleasant day!”

Flowers for Skeletor

Chapter Summary

> Hordak and Entrapta return to the Fright Zone. Perfuma gets a few things cleared up.

Entrapta and Hordak strolled into what had, once upon a time, been the heart of the Fright Zone. Now it was covered in lush greenery, and sunlight shone through the open spaces in the ceiling.

Entrapta was riding cross-legged on top of Emily, and gazed in wonder at everything around her. Hordak walked at her side, watching her expression warmly, while supporting the shuffling footsteps of the Horde drone she'd rebuilt and named 'Skeletor.'

"Am I supposed to be frightened?" Skeletor asked, incredulous, taking in the rebuilt ruins.

Hordak hushed him, but it was true that nearly all of the horror had gone from the place. Flowers bloomed on every vine. Soft moss covered the floors. The cushioned red throne in the center of it all rested atop a *much* shorter set of steps, and it was currently occupied by a giddy scorpion princess who was bouncing in her seat and waving.

"Entrapta! Hordak! Hi! Welcome! Thank you for coming! Oh, it's so good to have you visit here!" Scorpia bubbled.

"Hello Scorpia! And also Perfuma!" Entrapta hollered as they approached. The Princess of Plumeria, tending to a patch of roses sprouting on the side of Scorpia's throne, gave a little wave and smiled awkwardly in reply.

"Skeletor has come for you!" Skeletor declared.

Hordak flushed in embarrassment and quickly pushed the robot away. He bowed deeply before Scorpia. "*Ahem*. Thank you for

inviting us here, Princess. How is reconstruction progressing in the New Scorpion Kingdom?"

"Oh, no, Hordak," Scorpia admonished, smiling. "I'm an *official princess* now. That means you have to call my kingdom what I named it."

"Of course. My apologies," Hordak replied. "Tell me, how are things in…" His face appeared to visibly strain. "...The *Delight* Zone?"

"Oh, just peachy!" Scorpia beamed back. "We're working on turning all the garbage incinerators into pottery kilns. And those hydro-electric generators you helped us install? Wow!" She tapped her claw-tips guiltily. "Which, uh, is actually part of the reason I asked you here. See, one of them broke down, and…"

"Have no fear!" Entrapta announced, hefting an overstuffed toolbox. "We'll get to the bottom of it!"

Scorpia sighed in relief. "Oh, thank you! And it really is nice to have you visit since we started redecorating. There's so much less, uh, crushing brutalism. And Perfuma is putting flowers *everywhere!*"

"I like them! They're so pretty!" Entrapta gushed. "What do you think, Hordak?" she asked, plopping a daisy crown on his head.

Hordak made a noise.

"*Anyway*," Perfuma spoke up suddenly, standing stiffly at the arm of Scorpia's throne. "We should show Entrapta to the power generators before it gets too late. After all, it is a rare honor to host the Princess of Dryl and… her royal consort."

"Not that rare," Entrapta said, unoffended. "You saw us at therapy group yesterday."

"A *rare honor* that we would hate to besmirch with an excess of small talk!" Perfuma insisted. Her eye twitched, slightly. "Right this

way, please!”

They walked along bridges that had once looked over belching smokestacks and polluted junkyards. Now the view was of farmland under clear blue skies.

“We’ve been growing *vegetables!*” Scorpia boasted, sweeping her claw across it all. “And to help the plants grow, we started keeping an apiary for local pollinators in one of the old bugshell towers.”

“Bee-People!” Skeletor shouted in delight.

“This is *incredible!*” Entrapta cried, standing up on Emily to get a better look. “Hordak, look how much they’ve repurposed! It’s like a completely different place!”

“It is,” Hordak agreed, and he did not sound entirely displeased about it. A calm smile played at his lips.

Soon enough, they reached their destination. In an open-ceilinged space, several machines the size of small houses sat astride a clear-flowing artificial river. This place, like the others, was covered in verdant and blooming plant life. The sun shone down on a forest in the heart of a factory.

One of the large machines was not making noise, and its lights had gone dark. Scorpia rapped on it with a claw, and it made a hollow clanging sound.

“This is the, ah, problem area,” Scorpia said sheepishly. “It’s — ”

“Destroyed! Totally destroyed!” Skeletor interrupted. He rushed forward and peered at the silent machine. “What’s that? The fusion alarm? The main drive is about to explode!”

“No, Skeletor. Nothing is going to explode,” Hordak chided, as Scorpia hyperventilated. He guided the robot away from the

generator. “I need you to look after Emily while Entrapta diagnoses the source of the malfunction. Emily will be recording, so do not misbehave.”

“I had anticipated that, bat-ears,” Skeletor grumbled, but dutifully shepherded the spherical bot away from the group toward a cluster of trees with bright turquoise fruit. “We’ll be in the banshee jungle!”

“I’ll beep you when I need you, Emily!” Entrapta called cheerfully as she spread out her tools. She grabbed Scorpia. “All right. I need to get topside of this machine to find out what the problem is, and I’m gonna need your electrical magic to run some tests. So, upsy-daisy!”

“Oh, wow, hangout time!” Scorpia exclaimed. “That’s great, because I just got a new board game I wanted to tell you about, it’s called — whoop!”

Her words were cut off as Entrapta hoisted her in her hair and scaled the side of the generator like a purple spider.

Perfuma watched them go and then looked, finally, at Hordak. She coughed. “So,” she said.

Hordak waited.

“...How’s Wrong Hordak?” Perfuma asked eventually, reaching for one of their commonalities.

“Quite well,” Hordak answered. He began to sort some of Entrapta’s tools. “He is very grateful that you’ve started helping him with the Ex-Horde Therapy Group, by the way.”

“Oh. Well, I’m glad that you’ve been… going to it,” Perfuma said. She seemed to be choosing her words carefully. “The Princess Alliance wasn’t entirely in agreement about what to do with you at first, you know.”

“I am aware,” Hordak replied, flatly.

From the trees, Skeletor emerged, covered in colorful flowers and desperately clinging to an unhindered Emily.

“Stop! You shall not escape!” Skeletor protested. “Your puny lasers mean nothing to me!”

“Speaking of the group,” Perfuma continued. “I think this is actually the first time I’ve had a chance to talk to you outside of it since all the official business when the war ended.”

Hordak’s eyes narrowed. “Are you driving at something, Princess?” he asked, evenly. Quietly, he practiced a breathing exercise that he had, in fact, learned from Perfuma herself.

“Your hatred of me will work in my favor!” Skeletor wailed from behind them, trailing Emily by a vine.

Perfuma pouted and put her hands on her hips. “Look, just… You had *better* not do anything to hurt Entrapta, okay?”

“...What?” said Hordak.

“What?” said Skeletor.

Perfuma crossed her arms. “I *know* you’re a good guy now, but that doesn’t make you a… a good *guy*. Entrapta *really* likes you. If you break her heart, some *very* powerful people will be *very* upset with you. Just so you know.” She struck what was probably meant to be an intimidating pose.

Hordak finally turned to face her. His expression was one of shocked surprise. “You are concerned about Entrapta’s emotional safety with *me?*” he asked. “I understand *you* are the one who kept her on a leash.”

“I — ! That was — !” Perfuma faltered, raising a finger. “...Not my finest moment,” she finally admitted, deflating. “But I swear, we all only want her to be okay. There are some things Entrapta just doesn’t understand.”

Hordak seemed rather taken aback by this. Politely, yet firmly, he said, "I assure you, Entrapta understands everything she needs to perfectly well. Often better than I do."

He looked upwards in her direction, and the sun seemed to brighten on his face. "I… respect her. Incalculably. It is my privilege to learn from her."

"There is the answer to my evil needs!" Skeletor said, from somewhere.

Now it was Perfuma's turn to seem stunned. "You really do love her," she murmured, and couldn't help letting her eyes shift to where Scorpia sat and laughed in the sunshine.

Hordak followed her line of sight knowingly. "Entrapta is not the only one you are worried about," he deduced after a few moments.

Perfuma fretted. "Scorpia just has such a big heart!" she said, helplessly. "And she's new to being a princess. She got yanked around a lot with… with the Horde, and I don't want her to be taken advantage of like that again."

Hordak considered this seriously. After a long pause that was interrupted several times by the distant sound of Entrapta's hammering and various exclamations of delight, he ventured, "Perhaps Scorpia understands more than she appears to as well. She was exceptional, if unusual, while in… my employment. I expect she will only continue to grow and flower in her new position." He offered a friendly hand to Perfuma's shoulder. "Especially with someone who loves her at her side."

At this, Perfuma blushed furiously and quickly strode away from Hordak. "Hey, do you need anything from us up there?" She called to Scorpia and Entrapta. "A big vine-ladder maybe? Or some kind of robot stuff?"

"Bee-People?" Skeletor offered.

Perfuma finally seemed to notice him. "Why *is* Skeletor here, anyway?" she asked, turning to Hordak.

"Ah. This is to help improve his work for the therapy group," said Hordak. "Entrapta wanted to provide him with more exposure to social situations."

"That seems… contrived. But I'll allow it."

"Any more questions?" Skeletor asked.

Before anyone could reply, Entrapta slid back to the ground, with Scorpia in her wake. "I'm gonna need some more parts from the ship!" she announced brightly. "Hordak, can you try to balance the dynamo while I'm gone?"

"Certainly. That will allow us to safely remove the alternator."

"Exactly what I was thinking! And then we can connect the charging coils to the…"

"Excitation field," Hordak finished, sharing her smile.

Perfuma and Scorpia traded baffled looks.

Entrapta tweaked one of Hordak's ears. "You get it!" she giggled. "You're doing great, Hordikins! Back in a minute!" And with that, she was off again.

"'Hordikins,'" Perfuma repeated, rapidly losing all composure. Beside her, Scorpia made a tiny, ecstatic squeak.

Hordak turned to face them both in mute horror, suddenly realizing that he was still wearing the flower crown Entrapta had placed on his head earlier.

"I am *not* discussing this," he intoned, but he could tell from the looks on the princesses' faces that this particular trial was far from over.

“If that’s the way you want it,” Skeletor said, “Then that’s the way you get it!”

Three Courageous Hearts (and Skeletor)

Chapter Summary

> The Super Pal Trio reunites for an important mission. Skeletor tries to take over the world.

Entrapta sat in the middle of her Bright Moon laboratory, surrounded by scrap metal and alone, for the moment, except for the bot whose guts and wiring she was currently putting back together.

"My strength is returning!" the robot boasted. It was one of Horde Prime's old drones, reprogrammed and repurposed. Entrapta had named it 'Skeletor.'

"Almost finished!" Entrapta said. "Once I've got you welded back up, we can test out all the improvements I made to your social programming!"

"Meheheheh! The whole galaxy will soon fall before the awesome might of Skeletor!" Skeletor gloated. "Hail Skeletor!" He raised both fists toward the ceiling and shook them emphatically.

Entrapta tutted and sparked her welding torch. "No, not like that. You aren't meant for galactic conquest anymore," she reminded him. "This is so you can be a nicer helper for Wrong Hordak's therapy group, remember?"

"Listen, I am *not* nice, I am *not* kind, and I am *not* wonderful!"

Entrapta smiled and patted the robot on the shoulder with her hair. "You are, though."

Skeletor made a whining sound and seemed about to protest, but at that moment a knock came from outside. Ignoring the offended robot, Entrapta jumped to her feet and vaulted across the lab to open the door.

She saw the visitor on the other side and immediately brightened. "Oh! Hello, Catra. Did you come about that ring you wanted me to make? I'm almost finished with — "

"Shh! Not so *loud!*" Catra hissed. She pushed Entrapta back into the lab, shut the door, and gave an exaggerated glance in either direction before continuing. "Adora's eyes and ears could be *anywhere*. I want this to be a *surprise*, remember?"

"Ah. Of course. A surprise." Entrapta twiddled her hair and looked toward Hordak's side of the lab, where he'd been working on a remarkably similar and equally top-secret jewelry commission for Adora. "Well, my current data indicates she *definitely* doesn't suspect a thing, so I think you can relax."

Catra narrowed her eyes. "Good enough. Anyway, *no*, I'm not here about that. I'm here because you asked me to help with your ridiculous robot, for some reason."

"Oh, right!" Entrapta hair-walked back to the workbench where she'd left Skeletor. "I need an outside observer to test his interpersonal skills. Skeletor, say good morning to Catra. *Politely.*"

"Have you come to surrender to the forces of Skeletor?" Skeletor demanded.

Catra raised an eyebrow.

"Okay, so it's a work in progress," Entrapta admitted. "But it's so great that you're here! I hardly ever get to see you outside of therapy group."

"What? Sure you do." Catra took a slouching seat next to Skeletor and searched her memories. "You and Hordak came on that double date with us, right? That went… well? And I mean, group counts. I thought I'd hate it at first, but it's really nice to see everyone each week. I feel comfortable opening up about stuff there."

“Plus there are tiny snacks!” Entrapta agreed. “Oh, yes, and feelings. Being discussed in a structured and constructive manner. That’s more of what you were talking about, isn’t it?”

“No, the snacks are definitely a big draw.”

The two women shared a laugh, and in that moment Catra felt a little part of herself getting just a tiny bit better. Entrapta hummed happily, while a loose strand of her hair finished putting Skeletor back together.

“This better be worth it,” Skeletor griped.

“Oh, but it will!” Entrapta grinned and made an excited noise. “Now, time for the next test! Skeletor, run relationship-building subroutine eighty-five.”

Abruptly, Skeletor sat up, made a strange nasal outcry, and bounded off the workbench. “Join forces with *you?* Mehehehehehehe. Never!”

He beat his chest and stamped on the floor. “I am the most evil! The universe will be mine to rule! Mine! Mine! Myaah!”

Catra, startled, jumped to her feet and backed away as Skeletor began to aimlessly knock items off the shelves. “Um,” she said, worriedly. “I know this guy’s a grouch at the best of times, but is he supposed to act like *that?*”

Entrapta furrowed her brow. “Hm. Let me check the data.” She scanned her workpad thoughtfully, remaining seated while Skeletor seized a curtain rod and began running haphazardly through the workshop, swinging at whatever he came across. “Here we go! It looks like I *may or may not* have crossed some wires and accidentally reactivated his default programming for aggressive territorial acquisition.”

“What does *that* mean?” Catra yelped, leaping on top of a cabinet as Skeletor barreled past her, vanishing behind a pile of old machinery in the back of the lab.

“Here comes King Skeletor!” Skeletor yelled.

Entrapta looked apologetic. “He… *might* be trying to conquer the planet? It should be fine as long as he stays in the lab. Which he will, as long as he doesn’t find the teleportation booth.”

“The *what*.”

“Oh, you know.” Entrapta began gesticulating with her hands and her ponytails. “I have labs in all the kingdoms now, and it just takes so long to travel between them the usual way. So I did a study of Glimmer’s powers and combined that with some reverse-engineered tech from Horde Prime’s ship, and now I can jump between each of them instantly!” She smiled proudly, hands on her hips. “But don’t worry, it’s *extremely* well hidden.”

Skeletor’s voice floated out from the recesses of the lab: “A secret passage! Let’s see where it goes!” Moments later, there was a loud electrical crackle, followed by a green flash of light and the pungent smell of singed air. The back of the workshop went quiet.

Catra’s ears drooped. “Did he just…?”

Entrapta snapped on a pair of goggles and flashed her teeth. “‘Fraid so! We gotta go after him! For *science!*” She noticed Catra’s face. “Oh. And, uh, for Etheria too. I guess.”

Scorpia, Princess of the Delight Zone (née Fright), finished putting the last decorative touches on the room that had recently been designated as Entrapta’s visiting laboratory space. It was already covered in the same flowers and vines that Perfuma had added to the rest of the rejuvenated kingdom, but now Scorpia was injecting her own little bit of feng shui: some extra furniture here, a fizzy drink dispenser there, and a few purple-hued paintings on the walls. It was downright cozy.

“You know, this reminds me of good times with the Super Pal Trio,” Scorpia said to nobody in particular when she was finished.

"I mean, I *know* we were in the Horde then, and working for the forces of evil, and Catra made some *really questionable* decisions while we all helped build a reality-destroying portal, but still. We had some good times. I miss those times, sometimes."

She stared wistfully about the room for a few moments longer. Then the calm was interrupted by one of the larger machines sparking loudly to life, flashing brightly, and depositing Catra and Entrapta on the floor in a tangled heap. Scorpia cried out in surprise.

"Hi Scorpia," Catra said, waving limply. She seemed almost sheepish, but smiled despite it.

"Did Skeletor come by here?" Entrapta demanded.

"What, the cranky robot from therapy group?" Scorpia scratched her head. "No, I don't think so."

Entrapta made a note. "Okay, so he's not here. And he wasn't in Plumeria or the Kingdom of Snows either, so that means he must have gone to the Salineas lab!"

"Um, can I ask a question?" Scorpia interrupted. "Yeah. Sorry. Hey, what's going on?"

"Skeletor went bonkers and he's teleporting all over the place and Entrapta and I have to stop him before he takes over Etheria!" Catra answered, breathlessly.

"Really? Ooh, I bet I could help with that! Maybe. If you wanted," Scorpia suggested. She rubbed her chin thoughtfully. "I mean. There's not much going on here, and Perfuma is busy doing government stuff in Plumeria right now, so I've got the whole day free!"

"I know, I have your calendar schedule saved to my datapad," Entrapta replied. "So, you wanna help us catch a robot?"

"Do I?" Scorpia's eyes sparkled and her face lit up before she gathered both of the smaller women in a humongous double-hug. "Let's *go!* Super Pal Trio *to the rescue!*"

The air fizzed, and then all three women tumbled out of the teleporter onto the floor of Entrapta's Salineas lab.

"Wow, that tickles!" Scorpia remarked, standing up and brushing herself off. "You okay over there, Catra?"

"I'm fine," Catra said. "Anyone see Skeletor?"

"Look!" Entrapta squeaked.

Some dirty footprints and an unsubtle path of mild, petty destruction led from the teleportation machine and out of the laboratory. The trio followed it out the door (which, Catra noted, had been labeled "Nerd Room" in flowing Salinean font) and into the hallways of the palace.

After a few turns, they came upon a stormy Mermista, angrily huddled with a small cluster of palace guards.

"You!" Mermista shrieked, when she saw them. "I *knew* you would have something to do with this, Geek Princess! Whatever you did, fix it *right now!*"

Entrapta ambled over and tipped her welding mask like a hat. "Hello!" She greeted, smiling. "What seems to be the problem?"

"Your *stupid* skeleton robot broke in here and *stole all of my Mer-Mystery novels!*" Mermista fumed.

This seemed to take the trio by surprise. Catra looked to Entrapta. "I thought you said he was trying to take over the world?" she asked, incredulous.

"Books are the real treasures of the world!" Skeletor shouted from somewhere further down the hallway.

“After him! Entrapta squealed. “He’s probably going to the palace library to steal more!” She pulled a piece of tech from one of her pockets. “We can track him with my Skeletor-locating beacon! Look, it’s even got a cute little red button.”

Catra’s eyes went wide. “How long have you…?” she sputtered. She buried her face in her hands. “You know what? Never mind. It’s ‘a while.’ I already know the answer is ‘a while.’”

“It’s a funny story actually,” Entrapta explained. “See, I *thought* this was in my *other* overalls.”

“I don’t care! Just push the button!”

Entrapta pushed the button. A pinging signal rang out, and they followed it down the twisting palace hallways, leaving Mermista’s annoyed groaning behind them. Before long, they found themselves at the double-doors to the library’s main hall. Extending a hand of hair, Entrapta pushed them open.

“Too late, fools!” Skeletor cried from inside. “This mega-steel gate is impenetrable!”

The trio looked inside and saw that the robot had constructed a large fort out of books and chair cushions in the middle of the room. He crouched behind its walls and glared at them balefully. “Now it’s only a matter of time until the power of Grayskull is mine!”

“Okay, we’ve got this!” Entrapta reassured her companions. “Catra, I need you to use your *cat-like reflexes* to flush him out. I’ll keep track of his movements with the beacon. Then, when we’ve got him where we want him, Scorpia will use her *hugging strength* to contain the threat!”

“Roger!” Scorpia saluted.

“This is a terrible plan,” Catra said, getting ready to jump.

Entrapta laughed, maniacally. “Ha ha! Here we go!”

One fraught battle later, Scorpia held a wriggling, defeated Skeletor in her claws while Catra scolded the erstwhile robot and Entrapta cheerfully took data as they walked back down the disheveled hallways to the teleportation machine.

“Bad Skeletor. Bad robot,” Catra chided. “No more evil schemes for you.”

“You overgrown alley-cat! I’ll turn you into a suitcase!” Skeletor retorted. “You can’t do this to me! I’ll get you for this! Myaah!”

Strangely, the litany of insults only made Catra feel better about their decisive victory. Her heart swelled as she laughed along with the other two, and the feeling of belonging and togetherness lasted all the way down the hall, past Mermista’s impatient glare, into the teleporter, and beyond.

The Super Pal Trio had saved the day.

As soon as they were back in her Bright Moon lab, Entrapta took the captive robot from Scorpia and reached for a half dozen of her tools at once. In a blur, she opened Skeletor back up, twisted and soldered some wires, flipped a number of switches, and riveted him back shut. A softer expression seemed to float across the robot’s frowning face.

“I am your friend,” Skeletor stated in a calm voice. “I’ve come to help!”

Everyone in the room breathed a collective sigh of relief.

“What an adventure!” Entrapta cackled, breaking the silence. “And you two were great! Top-notch research assistants!” She flashed a double thumbs up at Catra and Scorpia and plopped into her seat at the workbench. She peered at her notes. “Anyway, you can both head back home now if you want. I’m probably just going to keep tinkering with Skeletor for the rest of the afternoon.” She flipped down her welding mask. “Don’t worry, I’ll be extra-careful this time. It’ll be perfectly safe!”

Catra and Scorpia shot each other a silent look of screaming panic.

"Actually, I think we'll stay a little longer!" Catra cut in, quickly. "You know. In case you need any more help with science stuff. Or whatever."

"I can get some board games from my place!" Scorpia added. "Uh, that is, if you teach me how to use the teleport-thingy."

Entrapta bounced back up on her hair, eyes shining. "Really? That would be great! Wait here, I'll go make us all some tiny cocoa!"

Hours later, the crackle of electricity and a soft glowing light filled Entrapta's laboratory in Dryl before the scientist herself emerged from the teleportation booth, worn out but looking immensely pleased.

She was greeted by the heavenly sight of Hordak, unarmored, relaxing in a large cushioned chair and reading peacefully while Imp napped beneath his arm. He looked up from his book and smiled as she approached.

"Welcome home, my dear. Did you have a good day with your friends?"

"Oh, it was incredible!" Entrapta tossed herself into her partner's lap and wrapped them both up in a swathe of her hair. Jostled by the movement, Imp yawned, blinked at her, and promptly fell back asleep. Entrapta scratched the smaller clone behind the ears.

"We went to the beach, and the library, and hung out in the lab! And Skeletor did *exactly* what I programmed him to. Relationship-building subroutine eighty-five was a *complete* success!"

Hordak's eyes crinkled as he smiled further. "Scorpia and Catra usually seem to appreciate your company," he pointed out. "I'm sure you could simply *ask* them to spend time with you, if you wished."

“And where’s the fun in that?” Entrapta pouted.

Hordak laughed. “Fair enough. You are quite devious when you have a mind for it, you know.”

“I’ve got a mind for a lot of things,” Entrapta murmured, and curled closer. They stayed that way until the stars had come out and the only light in the lab came from glowing screens and blinking bulbs.

“Well, my job’s done,” said Skeletor. “Glad I could help!”

Skeletor Lends a Hand

Chapter Summary

> The support group acts out. Wrong Hordak gets a taste of his own medicine.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"I am *Hordak!*" Catra shouted. "And I defy your *stupid face!*"

She opened her hand. Wrong Hordak, wearing a mop on his head and with two extra eyes drawn haphazardly on his face, slumped to the ground.

"Oh! I am falling!" he wailed from the floor. "I have fallen! I am dead! Woe be to Horde Prime!" He splayed his limbs and stuck out his tongue for extra emphasis, making a few more death rattles as he did so.

It was drama therapy day in Wrong Hordak's Ex-Horde support group.

Hordak, watching from the back of the small audience, hid his face in his hands and slouched as far down as he could in his chair. "This is the worst torture I have ever endured," he whispered.

"Oh, but this is the best part!" Entrapta squeaked. She squeezed his arm and leaned into his shoulder.

The stage, such as it was, consisted of a marked-off portion of the floor, faced by the other group members, who mostly consisted of Entrapta and Hordak and about two dozen enraptured clones. Scorpia and Perfuma were by the door, working the lights.

Catra-as-Hordak continued to yell at her defeated enemy. "Ha! Serves you *right*, you creepy evil jerk! I bet you didn't 'see all' *that* coming!"

"Catra! That's not the line!" Adora hissed. She was kneeling on the ground a few feet away, pretending to be tied up. Her hair was bunched into two ponytails, and she had borrowed Entrapta's welding mask.

"Ugh. *Fine*. Have it your way. *I turned against my brother! What have I done?*"

"Ca— I mean, Hordak!" Adora cried, standing up. Her acting was as wooden as ever, but she played the role seriously, holding Catra's face tenderly in her hands. "It's okay. You're free now. You can be whoever you want to be."

They kissed, passionately.

Hordak choked. "That did *not* happen!" he insisted, mortified.

"It would've been cute if it did, though," Entrapta mused beside him.

The room erupted into applause. "Bravo!" one of the clones cried, wiping away a tear. "Bra-*vah!*"

The lights came up. Wrong Hordak jumped to his feet and bowed to the group. "Thank you, brothers! Thank you!" He straightened. "Now, consider this thought experiment: what would you have said to yourselves if *you* were the one to cast the villainous Horde Prime to his doom?"

The clones looked stricken. "I would have called myself a traitor!" one gasped.

"Worse than a traitor!" a second clone agreed. "A monster!"

"An abomination!"

“And yet,” Wrong Hordak said, still smiling, “Would you call the great Hordak any of these cruel things today?”

“Of course not!” a clone blurted. “He is a hero!”

“He turned against the false ruler! For *love*,” another added.

“He knows *some* things!”

A hushed murmur fell over the clones as realization dawned.

“So you see,” Wrong Hordak explained patiently, “Even though Horde Prime is dead, his lies can still live within us. We must learn to recognize Prime’s evil voice, and replace it with our own! Only then will he truly be defeated.”

As the clones discussed this new idea with excitement, practicing saying positive things to one another, Catra worked her way around to the back of the group and leaned on Hordak and Entrapta’s chairs.

“Enjoying the show?” she asked, smirking. “I think I make a pretty good you, Hordak.”

Hordak sank even further in his seat. “I fail to see the practical side of all this,” he grumbled.

“It’s very practical!” Entrapta protested. “Data shows that acting out roles can help us embrace new perspectives of ourselves and others.”

“Yeah,” Catra teased. “I find this exercise to be cathartic *and* entertaining, don’t you?”

“Attention, everyone!” Wrong Hordak announced, from the front of the room. “Next, Princesses Perfuma and Scorpia will perform their reenactment of ‘She-Ra and Her True Love Save the Heart of Etheria’!”

“You know what,” Catra said, “I just realized I have to go to the bathroom right now immediately.” She spun on her heel and speed-walked out of the room with a look of panic in her eyes.

“Perhaps I spoke too soon. This could be most amusing after all,” Hordak chuckled. He put his arm around Entrapta, and they settled in to watch the show.

Later, when the meeting had ended, Wrong Hordak busied himself with tidying up the room. Most of the attendees were still there, talking amongst themselves as they gradually filtered out the door. Entrapta and Hordak were chatting amiably with Catra and Adora by the snack table. Scorpia and Perfuma giggled to each other by the window and danced a few halting steps to music only they could hear. Wrong Hordak smiled.

“I am so proud of my brothers,” he sighed happily. “They have learned so much!”

“Wonderfully horrible creatures!” his assistant piped up.

Wrong Hordak’s assistant was a robot, one of Horde Prime’s former drones that Entrapta had reprogrammed and given a voice. She called it ‘Skeletor.’

“We will form an alliance, but only until our task is complete!” Skeletor said.

“Indeed. Now then, my exalted brother, I have an important mission for you!” Wrong Hordak held out a broom and dustpan to Skeletor. The robot groused but took them and went to work anyway. As he did so, Wrong Hordak felt a hand tap him on the shoulder.

“Excuse me?”

Wrong Hordak turned around to find one of the other clones staring at him. “Oh! Greetings, brother.”

“Today was wonderful!” the clone complimented. “Your acting skills are marvelous. But I noticed you did not get a chance to berate Prime yourself.”

“No, of course not!” Wrong Hordak responded, smiling. “My purpose in this group is to help the others with their emotional journeys. Also, this exercise is about more than expressing anger. It is about self-actualization!”

“Well then, all the more reason for you to try it! You must find your own voice as well.” The clone pulled Skeletor away from sweeping the floor. “Here, practice on this drone! Drone, say something Horde Prime would say.”

“Er… You boob!” Skeletor tried.

The clone was unimpressed. “Something else.”

“The first one didn’t count,” Skeletor griped. “It was just practice. I was *teasing* the poor fool!”

“Then what would Horde Prime say? If he saw us making our own choices and thinking our own thoughts.”

Skeletor pondered this. After a moment, he shook his fists and shouted, “Get in line! I see you need a lesson in obedience!”

“Better,” the clone nodded, and then looked to Wrong Hordak. “And what would you say to that?”

Wrong Hordak hesitated. “I... I would say, I am no longer obedient to a tyrant!”

“Fool! You will serve *my* purposes!” Skeletor pressed.

“I will not!” Wrong Hordak pushed back, more confidently this time. “I serve only my friends.”

“Your friends only keep you around because it amuses them to have a pet!” Skeletor wheedled. “Be honest. Wouldn’t everyone be

much better off if you had never come here?"

"That is not true!" Wrong Hordak said. "And, and even if it were, *I* am better for coming here! I *want* to be here! I am *happy* here! The light of this world is more fulfilling than Prime's sickly light could *ever* hope to be!"

"Bravo!" the other clone applauded. "That's the spirit!"

"Take a bow!" Skeletor cheered.

"Oh my," Wrong Hordak breathed. "You were right, that was an exhilarating experience!"

"Exhilaration is my specialty," the other clone boasted, proudly.

Wrong Hordak looked at the clone a bit more closely. "Are you new to our group?" he asked, curiously.

"Ah… Sort of? I've been coming for the past couple weeks, actually," the clone admitted, and blinked. Sideways.

"Well, you will always be welcome and among friends here!" Wrong Hordak beamed. He gave a wink, and the air appeared to sparkle around him.

"O— Of course," the clone stammered, seemingly taken off guard. "Excuse me, I must go now." They turned and rushed away, hiding their face and making a noise that sounded a bit like an overheating radiator.

"What a nice person!" Wrong Hordak remarked, watching them go.

"Someone I could almost respect!" Skeletor agreed. "Meheheh

open it, expecting Catra or Scorpia dropping by for a visit. Instead, she found a nervously fidgeting clone looking back at her.

"Oh. Hello. Can I help you?" Entrapta asked.

The clone quickly stepped inside, and then in a flash of dark light they *weren't* a clone anymore, but a lithe, svelte lizard person.

"I am having a *crisis*," Double Trouble lamented, grabbing Entrapta by the shoulders. "And you're the *only* one who can *save* me!"

"Oh! I see. You're that shapeshifter!" Entrapta said. She blithely brushed Double Trouble's hands away and sat back on her hair, looking contemplative. "Catra and Hordak told me about you."

Double Trouble cringed. "They did? Well, that's awkward."

"...So, what can I do you for?" Entrapta pulled a pen and notepad out of her pocket and smiled expectantly.

"I— Really?" Double Trouble sat down on a piece of unused machinery. "Okay. In that case, it's just… now that all the clones have discovered *individuality*, I think I'm beginning to see where you were coming from," they admitted.

"I come from Dryl," Entrapta supplied helpfully.

"That's not what I..." Double Trouble sighed. "Look, can you just tell me what sort of things Wrong Hordak likes?"

Entrapta shrugged. "Cooking. Being dramatic. Rebelling. Why are you asking me?"

"I think I might actually be able to work with that," Double Trouble muttered. "And I have to ask you because— because you're the only person on the planet who knows how to *romance* one of these space bats." They leaned forward. "Now *dish*."

“What an unexpected pleasure!” Skeletor said. “I’ve waited a long time for this!”

See art for the opening scene by cosmiquealiene on tumblr here!

Chapter End Notes

Thank you to ineffablelabpartners on tumblr for the idea of “Princess Theatre feat. Wrong Hordak as Horde Prime” :)

Friends Are Where You Find Skeletor

Chapter Summary

> Perfuma has to be in charge again. Everybody finds somebody to lean on.

"And *that's* why I think physical paperwork is a severely outmoded form of record keeping!"

Perfuma smiled as she leaned on Scorpia's arm and listened to the taller woman talk. They were strolling down a hallway in Bright Moon palace, making their way toward the room where Wrong Hordak hosted his weekly support group for Ex-Horde members. Perfuma, despite not strictly meeting the criteria, had become a welcome and increasingly popular guest instructor.

Today, however, something seemed off as they approached the meeting room. Perfuma poked her head through the doorway. "Hello? Wrong Hordak?"

"Come in, you royal boob!" a voice called cheerfully from inside.

Perfuma stepped the rest of the way into the room and did her very best to remain serene. The nasal voice that greeted her did not belong to Wrong Hordak, but to the old Horde bot Entrapta had fixed up to be his assistant. The robot's name was 'Skeletor.'

"I, Skeletor, have brought you here to serve me!" said Skeletor.

"Yes, mhmm, that's very nice." Perfuma looked around and tapped her foot impatiently. "Do you know where Wrong Hordak is? I wanted to go over my newest self-regulation exercises with him before everyone else arrived."

"I'm afraid the plan has been changed," Skeletor explained. "I have word: '*I don't think I feel well!*' Yuck! The poor fool. How unpleasant it is!"

"Huh? You mean he's sick?" Perfuma looked back at Scorpia, who shrugged, and then to Skeletor again. "Then it's just us leading the group today. But that means…" Perfuma paled. "Oh no. That means I'll have to be in *charge* again!" she wailed miserably. "I only prepared for a ten-minute meditation and an aura healing! I can't lead the entire session; that's Wrong Hordak's job! This is going to be a *disaster!*"

"What? Nah, come on, it can't be that bad!" Scorpia clapped her girlfriend encouragingly on the back. "You've led your own groups before in Plumeria, and those were great!"

"Those were drum circles! And flower crown workshops!" Perfuma pulled at her hair, and then drew the taller woman close. "Look, I… I didn't really realize it until I started helping out here, but your lives in the Horde were *very challenging!* And don't tell anyone I told you this, but it's… a *lot* more intense than the emotional energies I'm used to working with."

"Aw, hey. Don't worry wildflower, your secret's safe with me!" Scorpia smiled warmly. "I'm *great* at keeping secrets. And I mean, *I* think you're doing a great job. You show up every week to help! That's gotta count for something!"

Perfuma slumped. "Wrong Hordak is the one who deals with the serious stuff. And he's *great* at helping everyone process that, because he *lived* it! And I… didn't. I'm useless." She looked down, seeming almost guilty.

"Hey, I don't wanna hear talk like that coming from my best gal!" Scorpia gripped Perfuma gently by the shoulders and stood her up straight. "You're brave, strong, loyal, and you give *amazing* hugs! You've got this!"

Perfuma sniffled. "You really think so?"

"I *know* so!"

"Forward, my lackeys! In the name of destruction!" Skeletor shouted.

Perfuma frowned and put her hands on her hips. “Well, I think the *first* thing we should do is remove any distractions and negative influences from the environment.” She looked to Skeletor, who was busy chortling and setting up chairs in a circle. “Skeletor, can you go to the markets and get some red halfmoon berries? Wrong Hordak wanted more organic options for the snack table.”

“Huh?” The robot hesitated and seemed skeptical, but after a moment he saluted, took up the old curtain rod he used as a walking staff, and strode purposefully out the door.

Perfuma watched him go and giggled. “That ought to keep him busy for a while. Halfmoon berries are *blue*.”

Scorpia’s eyes shone. “Oh my gosh, that is so sneaky! What next?”

Perfuma looked determined. “Next, we finish setting up the room and get ready to *help people find their harmony!*”

“I’ve lost my harmony,” Perfuma muttered through a wavering, grit-toothed smile.

The other group members — Adora, Catra, Hordak, Entrapta, and a smattering of clones — had arrived and were now speaking animatedly around the circle. Somehow the topic of conversation had turned to Horde Prime’s methods of mind control.

“That creepy slime pit, though,” Catra was saying. “That was the worst thing.”

“Prime called it a baptismal font,” Hordak affirmed, nodding. “The liquid is a diluted form of his essence. It consumes thoughts and memories that are not of Prime.”

“It’s also *sticky*,” Catra complained, showing her tongue in disgust. “And I never asked, was that a *regular* thing for you guys, or…?”

“I was sent to reconditioning for observing the stars too often,” one clone piped up. “I thought they were pretty,” he admitted more quietly.

“I smelled a flower once,” another added. “Prime was *furious* when he found out.”

Adora joined in. “Yeah, I think Shadow Weaver tried something like that on us once or twice? But, you know, I can’t really remember.”

She and Catra laughed at that. So did most of the others in the room.

Perfuma’s eyes boggled in horror. “That sounds… remarkably traumatic!” she squeaked, in as upbeat a voice as she could manage. “Perhaps we should… try some deep breathing?”

“Oh yeah, I used to do that all the time when I was alone on Beast Island and I thought nobody was ever coming for me!” Entrapta said brightly. “It’s loads of fun!”

Perfuma sank in her chair, as if under the burden of a tremendous weight.

“You okay there, hot stuff?” Scorpia whispered, leaning over in her seat. “Need a break or anything?”

“How can you possibly *handle* all of this?” Perfuma moaned. “Just *thinking* about it makes me feel angry and exhausted and helpless.”

“But we *are* handling it,” Scorpia said gently. She smiled. “Look around.”

Perfuma looked.

None of the clones held the hunched, fearful posture that she could remember seeing so often in the days after the war. Instead, they were relaxed, smiling, and chattered with one

another like lively birds. Adora and Entrapta leaned lovingly on their respective partners when they talked, while Catra and Hordak offered quiet gestures of encouragement to each other and to every clone who had the courage to speak up.

"We're all interconnected," Scorpia explained. "And we all help each other. You're a part of that, too."

Suddenly there was a commotion at the door.

"I've brought you a present!" Skeletor loudly announced. He had returned, and was carrying a basket of halfmoon berries, all of which had been hastily and obviously doused in red paint.

Perfuma braced herself for chaos, but saw to her surprise that if anything the room had grown more easygoing with Skeletor's arrival. The others greeted him warmly and laughed at all of his disgruntled exclamations.

"Try this! I want you to witness the effects of my genius firsthand!" said Skeletor.

Perfuma looked to Scorpia, who was grinning hugely. She slowly returned the smile, and then something shifted and she was laughing right along with everybody else. And Perfuma found herself reflecting that, perhaps, there were more ways to reach inner peace than she had thought.

And that was good.

It was later in the day. There was a knock upon Entrapta and Hordak's laboratory door. Skeletor answered it.

"My sensors warned me that you were coming!"

Double Trouble was leaning in the doorframe, tail-tip curled, grinning. "Thanks for covering for us today, bonesy," they said. "You're a *doll!* More than worth the price."

“Well, Double, what will you do for me?” Skeletor demanded in reply. “You and I have some unfinished business!”

“As promised, your treasure.” Double Trouble produced a stack of what appeared to be weathered romance novels, their covers depicting muscled barbarians locked in embrace. “*Voila!*”

Skeletor accepted the books eagerly. “And when you open them they explode, right?”

“Something like that.” Double Trouble shrugged. “Just look for the pages where the spine is most cracked if that’s what you’re interested in.”

Skeletor cackled and carted the books off to the back of the laboratory.

Entrapta, seated at a workbench further inside, looked up from a half-finished robo-puppy long enough to give a friendly wave to the lizard in the door. Double Trouble returned the gesture. Then, abruptly, a look of panic crossed their face and they scampered away.

Entrapta raised an eyebrow and turned to find that Hordak had silently appeared behind her in the workshop. He stared past her, out the now-empty doorway.

“Was that who I surmise it was?” Hordak asked, sounding more confused than upset. “What were *they* doing here?”

Entrapta’s eyes darted back and forth. “Er, no reason. *Definitely* not a Wrong Hordak-related reason!” She laughed, nervously.

Hordak sniffed. “Entrapta. Would this have anything to do with why my brother was absent from our meeting today?”

“Um… *no?*” Entrapta tried, unconvincingly.

“Is he *fraternizing* with that mercenary?”

“Oh gosh no. I think it was just lunch and a show,” Entrapta reassured him.

Hordak looked ill. His ears flattened. “I forbid it,” he protested weakly.

“Aw, come on!” Entrapta pleaded. “You can’t stand in the way of *love!* It’s the most powerful force in the universe!” She thought about this. “I mean, other than strong nuclear particle interaction.”

“I need to lie down,” Hordak said distantly.

Entrapta followed him out of the room, tugging on his arm with one ponytail. “Hey, think about it this way, Wrong Hordak probably won’t be bothering you as much now! We’ll have *lots* of time for our own experiments.”

Hordak slowed his pace and allowed his partner to wrap more of herself around him. “That is a fair point,” he conceded. “In fact, I was just coming to ask for your help with a small mechanical engineering problem I’ve encountered…”

And then they were back at it, lost in the science and each other’s words and minds. They withdrew into their sanctum. The walls echoed with their work.

“I’m so powerful I even impress myself!” Skeletor said. “Myaah!”

Fabulous Skeletor Powers

Chapter Summary

> She-Ra sings. Catra tries. Hordak prays. Entrapta says hey, what's going on?

Chapter Notes

> For best results, read after viewing "Fabulous Secret Powers" by SLACKCiRCUS on YouTube.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra awoke from a strange dream of She-Ra singing and dancing to the soft light of dawn. She yawned and shook the sleep from her head.

Adora was next to her, snoring as loudly as a landslide. Looking down at her Catra smiled and relaxed, which was a feeling she was still getting used to, nearly a year after the end of everything.

There had been times, alone in the Horde, when she had been unable to do anything but lie in bed at night and cry, trying desperately to flush out all the thoughts running around in her head.

Now, things were different. It felt a little peculiar. On bad days she still worried that she would never be able to make up for the damage she'd done, and didn't deserve the happiness she had now. In her better moments she was able to remember that it wasn't really about *getting* or *having*, but about trying all the time to see and return the love that had always been there for her.

Adora snorted and rolled over. Moving carefully so as not to disturb her, Catra rose and padded to the small kitchen of their Bright Moon home. Somewhere along the way she was joined by

Melog, mewling and pressing against her shins for attention. She gave it, and the space cat's tail twitched happily.

Without really having any particular plan in mind, Catra withdrew various ingredients from the cupboards and began to fix a modest breakfast. Before she had time to make any grievous cooking errors, Adora was suddenly awake and there behind her, hugging her, smiling, correcting the wayward cat's mistakes, and adding a healthy dose of her own.

Before long they had something made from eggs and bread and vegetables that was not only edible but downright delicious, at least compared to green ration bars. They sat at their small table and ate and laughed together while Melog lay curled at their feet and purred contentedly.

Adora appeared to be thinking about something. She had one hand thrust in her pocket and her chin rested in the other, face screwed up in careful contemplation. Finally, she seemed to come to a decision. She looked up and leaned forward with a grin. "Hey, stud," she started.

Catra burst into laughter, cutting off whatever Adora had been about to say next. "What was that? Was that supposed to be *smooth?*" she cackled.

Adora tried to recover. "Hey, I'm just kidding! Yeesh!" She waved her hands defensively. "I — Look, let me try that again."

But Catra wasn't really listening, because it had suddenly occurred to her that between the early morning sunlight streaming in through the window, the smell of their perfect breakfast, the warm, bursting feeling in her chest, and Adora sitting right in front of her, that this moment was absolutely, stomach-turningly *picturesque*.

That would have made her angry before. Now she felt something else.

Adora noticed her girlfriend's distant look and reached out for her. "Hey, what's going on?"

"Uh, not much!" Catra stammered, suddenly aware that she needed to get something from the other room, *immediately*. "I'll be right back!"

She rushed to the spot where she hid important things, reached between a small bag of catmint and a little ball with a jingle bell inside, and retrieved a tiny hinged box with Entrapta's factory seal of approval stamped on the lid.

She stuffed it deep in one pocket and hurried back to the kitchen table, heart pounding. Adora, in the meantime, had changed her sword into a golden toy mouse on a string and was letting Melog chase it across the floor.

"Oh good, you're back!" Adora sat up straight in her chair and brightened. "Listen, I didn't really plan to do this right now — I actually wasn't sure *when* exactly I was gonna do it *until* right now — but I've been thinking about… *stuff*. A lot. And this morning just felt so *perfect* and I was so *happy* that I thought, hey, maybe I should take a chance and…"

She trailed off. While she was talking she had withdrawn something from her own pocket and was fidgeting nervously with it. It, too, was a very small box, red and blue-black. Almost automatically, Catra produced hers.

They looked at each other soundlessly. A great number of things were said without words.

Ultimately it didn't matter who broke the silence first, because the conversation would have been the same either way:

"So… I have a question for you."

"I do, too."

"You first?"

“Together.”

Hordak awoke to the sound of a klaxon alarm going off. Entrapta sat up straight in bed beside him, instantly alert, eyes wide with excitement.

“It’s *happening!*” She cried. “Variable A has been exposed to Variable C! The reaction has begun!” She laughed, maniacal and exuberant.

Hordak arose, much more blearily than his partner, and smiled. “I was wondering when they were going to get around to that. We finished making their rings weeks ago.”

“To the observation dome!” Entrapta shouted, leaping to her feet. “For *science!*” She scuttled out the door and away in a blur of purple and enthusiasm. Chuckling softly, Hordak stood and followed after her.

He stepped outside of their shared room in the Crypto Castle and took a deep breath as he prepared to climb the high stairs to Entrapta’s tower lab. He liked walking them; there were faster and easier ways to the top of the tower but the plodding pattern of his footsteps helped him examine and order his thoughts.

Going up the spiral staircase always seemed like climbing a great hill. It felt good to have hope, and a destination. The closer he got to the top, the more clearly he could hear Entrapta’s cries of excitement. It was like approaching a sun. That felt good, too.

Soon enough he reached the door to the lab (it was already ajar) and gently pushed his way inside. His partner was there, at work in the center of everything, cross-legged in midair as her hair stretched in a dozen different directions.

Entrapta cooed over her scientific instruments, and as Hordak watched her he felt something powerful move in his chest. Happiness branched through his body and showed plainly on his face. He no longer felt the need to hide his feelings inside.

Coming out of his reverie, Hordak realized quickly that Entrapta was not the only one present. Also populating the lab were Emily, who was doing a headstand, Imp, who was egging her on by playing peppy recordings of Scorpia's voice, and a reprogrammed Horde drone Entrapta had named 'Skeletor,' who was shaking his fists and yelling.

"I'm talking to you, you dimwitted duo!" Skeletor shouted at the other two. "What is it that holds your attention more than the mighty Skeletor?"

Imp blew a raspberry and Emily made a dismissive beeping noise. They returned to ignoring him.

"How you vex me," Skeletor grumbled.

Hordak looked away from this scene and approached Entrapta. She turned and made a happy noise, reaching out to draw him closer.

Entrapta eagerly showed off her equipment. "Look, look!" She pointed to one of the screens. "This reading means that both of the ring boxes have been opened. And *this* one means they're both *wearing* them!"

She squealed in delight and leaned into Hordak's shoulder. "And I *could've* gotten a visual, too, but *somebody* said that would be rude." She stuck her tongue out, facetiously.

"There is nothing you could not do, if you set your mind to it," Hordak told her. He pointed to the screen. "Tell me, what do these numbers mean?"

"Heart rate and endorphin levels!" Entrapta replied, happy to explain her machinations. "And it seems like things are going well!" She looked thoughtful. "Hm. You know, I've never been to another princess' wedding before. I wonder if it involves magic? Or if they'll have tiny food? What kind of present do you think we should bring?"

"I have read about Etherian traditions regarding this institution," Hordak said, frowning. "This is going to be… *somewhat* more involved than our ceremony was, isn't it?"

"If you mean it won't be in a lab and there'll be more witnesses than Imp and the robots, then yes." Entrapta had concern in her eyes. "What's going on? Are you worried about the crowd? I know lots of tricks for staying calm in big groups."

Hordak shook his head. "I was more concerned about how the other guests would react to… well." He gestured vaguely to himself. "The ones who don't know us as well as the happy couple, I mean."

"There's also Wrong Hordak. And Scorpia. And Perfuma's getting to like you, too!" Entrapta pointed out. "Plus all the clones from our therapy group. You're kind of their hero, y'know."

"I cannot imagine why," Hordak said. He looked away for a moment, toward where Skeletor continued to bother Imp and Emily.

"You pathetic pair of pitiful pinheads!" Skeletor fumed. "Some day I'll have the power to destroy you! Some day!"

Imp grumbled and rode Emily to the other side of the lab, leaving the gangly troublemaker behind. Skeletor balled his fists and whined in frustration.

Hordak pursed his lips. "And that still leaves the matter of the other princesses, not to mention the citizenry. Ever since the revolution against Prime, I've hoped — "

"*And* he prays!" Skeletor suddenly cut in. "Myaah!"

Hordak sighed. "Yes, even that. Every day. To the planet, or whoever cares to listen, that I have not done irreparable harm to this world. Or the fellowship it is made up of. But I fear it may already be too late."

“Let me check the data!” Entrapta flipped rapidly through her screens. “Nope, Etheria is currently stable. Elemental readings are within parameters. You’re all good!”

Hordak smiled but did not look comforted. “Damage can go deeper than data, my dear,” he said.

“Ah, you’re referring to *feelings being hurt*.” The princess looked pleased with herself. “Well, I’ve got metrics for that, too. Everyone at Wrong Hordak’s therapy group is now twice as likely to initiate conversations with you while we’re there. Angry glares from people on the street are down forty percent since your cleanup and reconstruction work on Beast Island and Salineas. And...”

Entrapta put her hands on her hips and drew herself up to her full five feet. “You’re *my* lab partner. If anyone’s got a problem with that, I’ll fight them!” She stuck out her chin and flexed her arms.

Hordak’s worried expression softened. “I am humbled by your loyalty,” he said, sincerely. Then he grew pensive again. ”Do you... ever regret it?” he asked, touching a fingertip to the crystal on his collarbone and gazing at the matching one around Entrapta’s neck.

“A stupid question!” Skeletor interrupted.

“There’s no such thing,” Entrapta retorted. She picked the robot up with her hair and deposited him elsewhere, then turned her attention back to Hordak. “And to answer yours, no I do not. *That* data point remains unchanged.”

She flashed her eyes flirtatiously and handed him a graph. “Endearment, concupiscence, and intellectual stimulation, however, have all increased *considerably*. See for yourself!”

Hordak couldn’t help but smile as he reviewed her charts. The warm feeling returned to his chest. “I cannot argue with such fine research,” he relented.

“Data doesn’t lie!” Entrapta affirmed.

“You think you’re so smart!” Skeletor griped.

Without looking around, Entrapta picked him up again and placed him by the door. While he complained, Emily and Imp shooed him the rest of the way out, the latter playing a long recording of Skeletor’s own toothless insults as they went.

“You are still the finest scientist I know,” Hordak purred. He held out a hand. “May I assist you with your work?”

Entrapta beamed. “I thought you’d never ask!” She wrapped herself around him and drew him into her world. Hordak gladly followed. Together, they learned and discovered.

It was fabulous.

“Hordak and She-Ra, both defeated in the same day!” Skeletor said. “Ha! I should come to Etheria more often!”

Chapter End Notes

> This is probably going to be the last one for a little while, but it won’t be the last one ever (probably).
>
> I’ve been absolutely floored by the positive response to these stories. I’m so happy people are enjoying them, and I’m grateful for every single comment!
>
> Skeletor will return in December(ish) for “Hordak and Skeletor: A She-Ra Day Special” (unless I change my mind).
>
> Thank you so much for reading!

Skeletor Takes a Holiday

Chapter Summary

> Catra thinks on the past. Adora gives out presents. Glimmer looks to the future. Entrapta drives a tank. Hordak and Bow do their best. A She-Ra Day Special.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Blast you, you miserable cat! Let me go!" Skeletor squawked.

"Reel it in, bonehead," Catra replied coolly. She was leading Entrapta's rebellious reprogrammed robot by what amounted to an ear, his arms full of stolen sugar plums.

"Please, let me explain!" Skeletor protested. "I *must* save the children!"

"Tell it to the queen," Catra shrugged back. "If you really wanted to get away with it, you wouldn't have let me catch you. And anyway, Wrong Hordak says we need more help at the snack tables."

"You overgrown fur coat," Skeletor grumbled. "How dare you embarrass me in front of everyone?"

They were walking down a hallway of Bright Moon palace, making their way toward one of the large common rooms. On most weeks, Wrong Hordak used the space to hold a support group for clones and other former members of the Horde, who met to talk about their lives and their feelings. Together, they healed, held on, and let go. And, with great bravery and reluctance, they tried new ways to be themselves.

Today, they were hosting a wellness afternoon.

Catra pushed open a pair of double doors and was greeted by the sight of a warm, bustling room. The therapy group regulars were there, but so were various palace staff and citizens of Bright Moon, as well as former Horde soldiers cautiously following the flyers distributed by an enthusiastic flock of clones. Mixed together, they mingled, tentatively.

Stations were set up in this and the adjoining rooms, each providing sample servings of various simple self-care options. In one area, Netossa and Spinnerella taught comics and cartooning to a circle of curious clones. In another, Swift Wind pranced at the head of an aerobics group. Glimmer had set up a portable kitchen by the window and was showing some palace guards how to make vegetable dumplings. Just about everyone looked like they were having a good time.

Catra waded through all of this and found Wrong Hordak teaching an improv comedy workshop — alongside the regular support group's newest member, who was currently hanging off the cheerful clone's shoulder like a feathered boa constrictor.

"Yes, *and?*" Double Trouble prompted the group, raising an emphatic hand. "Tell me what comes next! Show me *passion!* Show me *imagination!*"

"Start the performance! I demand to be amused!" interrupted Skeletor.

Everyone fell silent and turned to look at Catra. "I got Skeletor back," she said simply, showing off her perturbed prisoner.

"Wonderful work!" Wrong Hordak exclaimed. He pulled a small instruction manual bearing the seal of Dryl out of his pocket and flipped through the handwritten pages. "Skeletor, please perform…" He squinted at the messy longhand. "...Relationship-building subroutine *eighteen*. Ah, I think I see what the problem was."

Skeletor abruptly saluted, dropping most of his plums in the process. “I hate to leave this touching scene, but I see my plan has failed! I’ll be back another time, my friend,” he said, marching off to greet new arrivals and attend to the snack tables.

Catra turned to go, but found her way blocked when Double Trouble materialized in front of her.

“It’s good to see you back, kitten,” the lizard smirked. “We *almost* thought you’d abandoned us! And speaking of, look who I found while you were away.” They pointed. “Some old friends of yours!”

Following the gesture, Catra looked around and felt her insides do a flip-flop as she recognized Kyle, Lonnie, and Rogelio among the group. Double Trouble seemed about to say more, but was instantly distracted when Wrong Hordak winked and called them over for help with an armload of props and costumes.

...Which left Catra alone to face her three erstwhile friends. Who had already made eye contact and started walking towards her. The former force captain wished furiously for an alien abduction, or to be struck down by lightning, but she had no such luck.

“Hi Catra!” Kyle squeaked. Rogelio rumbled something in a friendly tone.

“Catra,” Lonnie greeted simply, wearing an unreadable expression.

“Oh wow,” Catra stammered. “It’s, uh, it’s been a while guys. Haven’t seen you since…”

“Since you went off the deep end and we deserted the Horde?” Lonnie finished for her.

Catra shrank a little. “Yeah. Since that. I’m… really sorry about all that, by the way. Have you all been okay?”

“We stick together. We have a good life. And we heard that you and Adora got married, so now I guess I owe Rogelio money.”

Lonnie laughed. “No invitations for us, huh?”

“It was really small,” Catra muttered, feeling worse by the second. She touched her ring. “Just a few guests in the park. Nothing major.”

Lonnie held up her hands. “Hey, it’s cool, none taken. I just hope you treat her better now than you did when we were in the Horde.”

Catra felt her hackles rise and did everything she could to squash them back down again. “We’re fine,” she managed, eventually. “You haven’t seen her around anywhere, have you?”

“Yeah. Over by the board games with the science princess and, you know...” Lonnie mimed a tall, fanged figure with a squinting scowl. “Though I still don’t know how I feel about those two.”

Kyle and Rogelio looked at each other.

“Thanks,” Catra muttered, and slunk away.

Catra found herself stuck in her own thoughts as she wandered in the direction Lonnie had pointed, barely able to muster a friendly wave as she passed Scorpia in Perfuma’s yoga group or Bow at the jigsaw puzzle table. She kept replaying the conversation in her head, thinking about things she could or would or should have said.

In the pit of her chest, she could feel the faint fear of a voice that said she hadn’t changed at all. Unbidden, the image of her own hand on the portal lever came to her. *Stupid, stupid,* she thought at herself, until the self-loathing drove away the shame.

Catra sighed. She was *working* on it.

Fortunately, she didn’t have long to perseverate. Sure enough, Adora was in the board games area, seated around a table with Entrapta, Hordak, Emily, and Imp. All five of them were

thoroughly engrossed in a heated round of *Betrayal at Horror Hall*.

"I've rolled a three," Hordak declared as Catra approached. "Is that good?"

"No, it means you're still trapped in the Dark Dimension," Entrapta explained evenly. "My turn! I move into the throne room and attack the ghost!"

"Attack! Attack!" Imp echoed in her voice.

Emily beeped.

"Hey Adora," Catra sighed with relief as she joined them. "How's it going?"

"Emily betrayed us all, the Dark One has escaped, and I'm dead!" Adora wailed. "In the game, I mean," she clarified, gesturing to her battle figurine, which was tipped on its side. Catra smiled and settled in, already feeling more assured of herself.

"Oh, and you have *got* to try Hordak's new coffee," Adora continued, proffering a steaming paper cup. "He called it a… peppered mint mo-cah?" She looked at Catra with immeasurable eyes and giggled. "I think I can *hear* space."

Catra had a thought. She glanced at Entrapta.

"That reminds me," Catra started cautiously. "You know that charity stunt or whatever you goons have planned for the night before Adora's birthday?"

"You mean She-Ra Day Eve?" Adora asked, a huge grin plastered on her face.

"Yeah, that one. I changed my mind about staying home. I want in."

"Oh, yay!" Adora nearly fell out of her seat leaning over to hug her wife. "We're gonna have so much *fun!*"

"It will be a significant benefit to have extra helpers," Hordak added with approval as he looked up from the game board. "Entrapta has engineered quite an undertaking for this event."

"She has? Uh, how elaborate are we talking, exactly?" Catra asked, already beginning to regret her decision.

Entrapta leaned across the table. "Oh, it's gonna be *big*," she boasted, grinning. Then she sat back in her hair and laughed madly, swinging her feet with delight.

Catra gulped. Somewhere, she could hear a bell ring.

They were standing outside in the starry night.

It did not snow in Bright Moon, but the air was chilly, and everyone assembled was wearing heavy winter coats. Catra, sinking into hers like a turtle, leaned against Adora's arm and groaned.

"I'm gonna be *so bad* at this," she complained.

"You're gonna do *fine*," Adora cajoled. "You'll get to throw stuff at people! You love doing that."

"It wouldn't be the same without the whole Best Friends Squad anyway!" Bow added, as Glimmer nodded beside him.

"It's better with you here," the queen said, smiling.

Catra felt her stomach twist and looked away. But that only faced her toward the group's tallest member, looming lazily on her other side.

"You seem stressed, Catra."

Catra glared back up at Hordak. “Easy for you to say! *Your* wife’s birthday isn’t a national holiday!”

Hordak huffed. “Perhaps not where you come from.”

“I can’t take much more of this,” moaned Skeletor.

Catra threw up her hands. “Okay, and why is *Skeletor* here?” she asked helplessly.

“Silence, you furry fool!” Skeletor retorted. “You ought to know me better than that by now!” He crossed his arms and sulked.

“We require a full crew for this endeavor,” Hordak explained, more calmly. “Entrapta insisted upon using one of the larger models.”

“Models of what?” Catra demanded.

As if on cue, a loud rumbling sound filled the air. The ground began to shake, and an enormous Horde tank rounded the corner, trundled down the road, and came to a juddering halt in front of the gathered friends. It was covered in tinsel and had been repainted with jolly, festive colors.

“Speak of the gremlin,” Catra mumbled, staring.

The tank’s front hatch popped open and Entrapta emerged astride Emily, hefting a huge burlap bag. Imp was sitting on her shoulder, wearing a new pair of booties with curled and pointed toes.

“Merry She-Ra, one and all!” Entrapta crowed. “Welcome aboard the Wrapper Tank!” As they filed past her up the ramp, she rummaged in her bag and passed out what appeared to be accessorized figurines resembling each member of the group.

Skeletor stared long and hard at his. “Only one is really me! Which one is it?” he mused.

Glimmer was delighted with hers and immediately set about making it hold hands with Bow’s. Catra held hers uncertainly while

Adora toyed with the miniature She-Ra's sword arm action.

"Look, it's a tiny Hordak!" Entrapta squealed with glee as she presented her partner with his own likeness. "Isn't he cute?"

Hordak smiled as he accepted the gift. "Your craftsmanship is remarkable, as always."

Inside the tank was a command bridge the size of a throne room. Several more bags stuffed with small toy princesses rested in the center of the floor. On every surrounding wall there were blinking control panels and swiveling gunners' chairs. Skeletor sat down in one and spun giddily.

"I made tiny versions of all the heroes of Etheria!" Entrapta exclaimed, sweeping her hands over everything. "Bow helped with the designs. And then I used my fabrication lab to mass-produce them!" She held her sides and cackled wildly.

"We're going to give them out to all the homes in Bright Moon," Adora added, settling into another chair. "Something for the kids, you know?" Catra, already brightening at the sight of weaponry, grinned and joined her.

Entrapta tossed herself back into the pilot's seat. "If this experiment goes well, we'll be able to expand the operation to other kingdoms next year! Maybe even the whole planet!"

"Okay, but how are we going to be able to deliver presents to *every* house if we only have *one* night?" Bow asked.

"That's easy!" Entrapta bragged. "Behold, the power of the Wrapper Tank!"

With a flourish, she dropped one of the trinkets into a large funnel near the control panel. In seconds, automated arms had bound it in wrapping paper and a purple bow, and fired it out the front cannon at high velocity.

“This baby can do thirty of these things a minute!” Entrapta shouted proudly as she continued shoveling toys into the machine.

“Is everyone comfortable?” Skeletor asked. He didn’t wait for an answer before pushing as many buttons as his bony arms could reach.

With a roar, the engines came to life, and then they were rolling down the road, strafing the kingdom with presents that mostly landed where they were supposed to go. The inside of the tank became a bustle of activity as the crewmates passed gifts to one another and sent them shooting off into the night. Distantly, they could hear people cheering, as well as the occasional sound of something breaking.

“Is this what we’re doing all night?” Catra asked. She flipped a switch and raised her eyebrows as a Frosta doll hurtled through someone’s window. “You were right, it is kinda fun.”

“This is the main event, yeah,” Adora replied, launching a volley of Sea Hawks down the block. “We’ve got a few more personal stops to make on the way, though. The first one’s in the Whispering Woods!”

Catra froze for a moment, imagining the ghosts that were waiting for her in those dark and shifting trees. She shook her head and ignored the thought.

“What idiot started this whole thing anyway?” Skeletor griped.

The tank made its first stop at a tiny cottage, so small and low that it would have been easy to mistake for nothing at all.

“Madame Razz?” Adora called as she ducked through the doorway. The others followed behind her in a curious huddle.

“I brought you some cookies and sweets and stuff,” Adora said, setting the goodies on the table. Bow and Glimmer gazed with

interest at the many mystical odds and ends decorating the walls. Entrapta struck up a conversation with the broom. Hordak, who was taller than the ceiling, crouched in as dignified a manner as he could manage.

"Who knows what evil lurks behind these doors?" Skeletor hissed in a hushed whisper.

At the far side of the cottage, Razz sat in a rocking chair and tipped slowly back and forth, staring at nothing. Catra felt her hair stand on end.

Adora looked worried. "Razz? You there?"

Madame Razz blinked and snapped out of her trance. "Yes, yes, deary! Come in! I remembered this was going to happen." Leaping to her feet, she held out a stuffed doll with pointed ears, blue hair, and soulless eyes. "Look here! I have a gift for you also."

Adora took it gingerly. "How… nice. What is it?" She turned the doll over in her hands. It wore a rainbow jumper and a plastic smirk.

"It's a Loo-Kee on a Ledge!" Razz explained cheerfully. "You put it in your home. Move it every night. Tell the children it can see them. Makes the young ones more obedient!"

"Thanks, that's terrifying." Adora passed the doll to Catra, who seemed far more interested in its potential applications. "I bet it'll make a nice game."

"Game?" Razz turned and stared through her glasses in confusion. "We are not here for games, we are here for fruit cake!"

Before Adora could stop her, the old woman had rushed to her little cottage oven. She made a show of reaching inside with protective mitts and extracted a cold stone brick, which had been placed in a pan with some wild nuts sprinkled on top.

"You want a slice now?"

“Oh, absolutely!” Entrapta pushed her way to the front of the group, producing a small buzz saw and a sample jar. “I’ve been reading up on geological gastronomy!”

”Uh, hey, Entrapta!” Adora intervened. “Did I ever tell you that Madame Razz knew some of the First Ones? Like, personally?”

“What? Really?” Entrapta turned toward Adora in surprise, and then back to the old woman with renewed interest. She peered through a pair of multi-lensed goggles and raised her eyebrows. “Though that would explain all the tachyons in here. Quick, how many temporal causalities am I holding up?”

“Ah! You’re a sharp one, deary!” Razz laughed.

Entrapta shook her hands and pulled a recorder from her pocket. “Aah! You — you’re a walking quantum event! Tell me *everything!*”

And in her own way, Razz did. As they chattered back and forth, Adora looked between the old witch and the scientist and wondered why she hadn’t introduced the two of them sooner.

“That’s a handsome, strapping lad you’ve got there!” Razz whispered conspiratorially to Entrapta. “Does he have a brother?”

Entrapta smirked.

“You have a brain that could warm my heart,” Skeletor said. “If I had a heart!”

Much to Catra’s consternation, their next stop did not take them out of the Whispering Woods. While Entrapta and Skeletor tuned up the tank, George and Lance cheerfully embarrassed their youngest son in front of his friends.

“We’re delighted by your *presents!*” George punned as his husband passed out mugs of hot cocoa. Hordak took two and carefully decanted the extra into several tiny thermoses.

Bow handed his fathers a huge stack of neatly handwritten pages. "We brought these for you — Adora's been helping me translate some of the First Ones records you found at the ruins!"

"It's… not very exciting," Adora admitted. "There's a *lot* of complaining about this one guy who just sold really terrible etherium."

Despite this, George and Lance seized upon the pages and flipped through them eagerly, talking over each other in excitement. While they sat and chatted energetically with Adora about what the writings contained, Glimmer dragged Catra away to show off her increasing knowledge of the expansive library.

This left Bow standing alone with Hordak for the first time in the night. The archer and the ex-lord looked at one another, the former desperately searching for something to say while the latter gently nursed his cocoa. They both seemed to sense that some sort of social interaction would be appropriate, but were entirely unsure of what that ought to be.

"Excuses, excuses! I'm tired of all your excuses!" Skeletor yelled from outside. "Fix the problem and go!"

Hordak cleared his throat. "Entrapta tells me you are the one who gave my brother his rather... derivative name," he tried after a moment.

Bow made a noise.

"He thanks you for it," Hordak said sincerely.

"I'm sorry! I mean, what?" Bow cautiously opened his eyes.

"He considers it an essential part of his journey to freedom from Prime's grasp." Hordak studied his claws with a careful expression. "Many have encouraged him to take on a more singular moniker. I am among them. Perhaps someday he will. But for now, it is as beloved to him as that theatrical lizard seems to be."

“You’re… welcome?” Bow ventured.

“You are a highly competent engineer,” Hordak stated. “I once mistook your work for Entrapta’s. When we were still enemies, that is.” He hesitated. “I… am pleased that we are not enemies any longer.”

“Thank you?”

Hordak bowed.

Skeletor popped his head around the door.

“Get a move on, you slugs!” he called. “Hurry! Faster, faster!”

Eventually, the Wrapper Tank rolled to a stop at the front gates of Bright Moon palace, precisely where it had begun. There was only one visit left to make.

“Micah! It’s so good to see you!” Entrapta chirped. “How have things been since we both lived at the mercy of techno-organic island monstrosities?”

“Quieter,” Micah remarked. “And my food doesn’t get stolen nearly as often.” He smiled. “It’s good to see you, too.”

“I made you She-Ra Day crackers!” Entrapta exulted, holding out a pile of shiny paper cylinders. “They’re an old Dryl tradition, ever since last year. When you pull the ends, tiny snacks come out! And I’ve improved *these* ones with twenty percent more explosives!”

“It should be quite a blast!” Skeletor chuckled. “Enjoy the fireworks!”

Gingerly taking the armload of gifts and setting them down as carefully as she possibly could, Castaspella welcomed everyone into a warm and cozy den. She and Micah had lit a roaring fire in the fireplace and were decorating a fir tree with glowing light-

charms. A small table held a large platter of cookies, which Adora immediately set about devouring.

Skeletor paused at the door. “Tell me a riddle!” he demanded.

Castaspella looked confused. “Excuse me?”

“He thinks it’s what sorceresses do,” Entrapta told her. “You gotta humor him!”

“Oh.” Castaspella tapped her chin. “Well, in that case, um… why did the twigget cross the road?”

Skeletor considered this for a great deal of time before surrendering. “Oh, I’m horrible at riddles,” he groused. “Who’s good at riddles here?”

However, everyone else had already settled in around the fire, tired from a long night of bauble bombardment.

“What do you think of our She-Ra Day decorations?” Castaspella asked proddingly. “Micah wanted a fake tree, but I set him straight on *that*. Honestly, I don’t know *how* my brother survived on Beast Island without me.”

“You certainly would have helped scare the monsters away,” said Micah.

“Y’know, I’ve always wondered what it would be like to have a sibling,” Adora thought out loud. “Could you imagine me with, like, a long-lost First Ones twin? We’d kick so much butt!”

Hordak, Bow, Micah, and Castaspella all shared a look that spoke to something universal.

“It’s a mixed bag. Casta used to trick me into stealing food for her,” Micah complained. “Pretended it was a game and I got more points if our parents didn’t see me sneak into the kitchen.”

“He hit me with a tree branch once, you know,” Castaspella responded.

“I did no such thing!” Micah argued. “All I did was lead your horse under a tree. It’s not *my* fault it had remarkably low hanging branches. Or that you didn’t duck in time.”

“*Anyway*,” Bow cut in, “I think what Micah and Castaspella are *trying* to say is that despite their differences they get along *now* and they’re glad to still have each other after all this time.” He glanced at Hordak. “...Even if they used to be enemies.”

Micah nodded sagely. “That is *precisely* what I meant,” he lied.

While they continued with their conversation, Glimmer noticed that Catra was standing alone at the far side of the room, her back to the others, staring at a small portrait of Angella hung above the door.

“Fascinating,” Skeletor said. “That little insect is feeling sorry for itself!”

Glimmer whispered something to her father and stood up to approach the fretting feline. “Hey, everything okay?” she asked. “You’ve seemed off a lot tonight. You didn’t even laugh when I showed you that book of dirty First Ones jokes in George and Lance’s library.”

“Huh?” Catra looked up, surprised to have company. “I guess so. Maybe. I don’t know. I mean… are you really sure I should be here?”

“Well, it’s all Adora has been talking about for the past week, so yeah, pretty sure.”

Catra shook her head. “No, I mean here *at all*. Being happy, instead of rotting in a dungeon somewhere.” She scowled. “I know we’ve talked about it, but I just… I did *so much* bad stuff, back in the Horde. I hurt people. I was *awful* to Adora. I’m even the reason your mom…”

Catra trailed off. A deep gulf of silence stretched between her and Glimmer. The queen appeared pensive.

"I've done some really bad things too," Glimmer said eventually. "So I guess maybe I'm the wrong person to ask?" She gave a lopsided smile.

"But what do you do when people *hate* you? And you *deserve* it?"

Glimmer looked concerned. "I don't think anyone here hates you. Not currently, anyway. Where's all this coming from?"

"I'd hate me if I were you," Catra quietly admitted.

"Maybe. But I'm not you, and you're not me." Glimmer turned away and hugged herself. "I'm always going to miss my mom. And it's always going to hurt. But… I don't think it's much use to make that hurt worse by hating you." She looked back up. "I think anyone can make up for a mistake, as long as they really know it *was* a mistake. I *hope* so, anyway."

Catra scratched her head. "So, what, feeling *bad* means that I'm *good?*"

"Something like that," Glimmer giggled. "Seriously though, there's responsibility in this. We never stop working on it."

"Was that a royal 'we'?" Catra quipped.

"No, it goes for both of us. All of us. I mean it." Glimmer gazed around the room. "Mistakes… never really get completely fixed, you know. It took me a long time to get that. But we *can* grow something better and stronger with the lessons we learn from them."

The queen smiled again. "Besides, I'm happier being friends. Look at us all!"

Catra did.

Everyone, in one form or another, was relaxing around the glow of the fireplace. Entrapta and Imp knelt by the hearth, doing something with chestnuts and an acetylene torch. Hordak and Micah sat on the couch, swapping horror stories about Shadow Weaver. Bow watched closely as Castaspella instructed him in a new knitting pattern. And Adora appeared to be trading pleasantries with Skeletor as though they were age-old friends.

"Here, She-Ra! A gift!" Skeletor said. He held out a freshly-baked doomberry pie.

Catra laughed. Suddenly feeling lighter, she went to join them. Glimmer followed. And the great world spun on.

Entrapta clapped her hair. "Thanks for coming, Catra! This was loads of fun!"

It was early morning and they were all going their separate ways again. Glimmer had already dragged a dozing Bow back to the palace, while Catra and Adora disembarked in front of the small home they shared together.

"The mission was a great success," Hordak agreed as Entrapta leaned into his side. "You showed exemplary courage in the field."

"Thank you," Catra said, and meant it.

Adora, gazing at the sky in contemplation next to her, suddenly realized that the stars weren't the only things twinkling.

"Entrapta?" she asked. "You know the space tree?"

"The large plant growth that overtook Horde Prime's flagship when She-Ra defeated him and which remains in low Etheria orbit as a constant reminder of the power of love and healing? Yes, I'm familiar with it."

"Did you put *lights* on it?"

Entrapta beamed. “Yeah, little blinky ones! Or at least they look little from here. They actually have a diameter of about one Darla each. Alternating current, naturally. Aren’t they great?”

“You know,” Adora smiled, “I really think they are.” Catra concurred.

They turned and went home together, which left Entrapta and Hordak to return to the Wrapper Tank hand in hand, relaxing into each other’s arms as they sat and shared a tiny thermos of hot cocoa. Under Emily’s supervision, Skeletor and Imp drove the tank back to Entrapta’s Bright Moon lab, and only argued over the steering wheel once along the way.

As soon as they returned, Hordak sought out their bed and fell gratefully into the soft sheets. Entrapta made to follow him, but before she did so she pulled Skeletor aside with one ponytail, hands hiding something behind her back.

“And what do you think you’re doing?” Skeletor questioned.

“Skeletor, you’ve been a big help over the past year,” Entrapta said to the spindly robot. “And I wanted to say thank you. So, I made you another present. You deserve to have a helper too!”

She pulled her hands from behind her back and revealed a lop-eared robot puppy with wide and innocent eyes. It sat up in her arms and fixed Skeletor with a curious gaze.

“His name is Relay! What do you think?”

Skeletor gasped in surprise, reaching out to take the robotic canine. “Even Hordak doesn’t have anything like this!” he gushed in a joyous tone.

The puppy wagged its tail and let out a tiny synthesized bark. It licked Skeletor’s face.

Skeletor hummed happily. “This is perfect!”

Above them, the stars and the lights shone brightly. The world was at peace. And even Skeletor, despite his better instincts, was merry.

“A season of love? Caring? Joy? Ugh! Very clever, you muscle-bound moron,” he groaned. But Skeletor still smiled, and patted Relay on the head…

…and felt *good*.

Chapter End Notes

Many thanks to my lawfully wedded lab partner for the "Loo-Kee on a Ledge" and "improved She-Ra Day crackers" jokes.

This was originally going to be called "Hordak and Skeletor: A She-Ra Day Special" but the cast just kept expanding and now here we are. I enjoyed writing some characters I hadn't before!

Incidentally, back in the library Hordak means "derivative" in the linguistic sense, not the derogatory one, but he also doesn't know that Bow doesn't know that.

Relay the robo-puppy originally appeared for the first (and only) time in the 1985 He-Man and She-Ra Christmas special. He loved Skeletor then and he loves him now.

Whatever holidays you do or don't celebrate, thank you so much for reading and I hope you have a splendid season! I treasure every comment and I'm grateful for any enjoyment these stories may have brought you. Expect the next one around summertime.

Myaah!

Romeo and Skeletor

Chapter Summary

> Double Trouble needs dating advice. The Super Pal Trio is here to help.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Remember," Wrong Hordak recited, "recovery comes from connection!"

Several hands went up. Most belonged to clones. This was a common and welcome sight in Wrong Hordak's Ex-Horde Therapy Group.

"And no," Wrong Hordak continued, anticipating everyone's question, "that does *not* necessarily mean romantic connection, or even connection with another sentient being. It means that in order to heal our traumas, we must be a part of the world around us, and acknowledge the world as a part of us."

Most of the hands went down. Thoughtful murmurs rippled through the crowd. It was the end of another day of helping and healing. With a few more words of wisdom Wrong Hordak closed the meeting, and the assembled members began to stand and make their way out of the room. Most seemed sanguine and cheerful, but one stayed seated and watched the others wearily.

Double Trouble was the group's newest and most skeptical member. They were *trying*, they *really* were, but it wasn't easy. A lifetime of artful deception did not exactly lend itself to *sharing* or *emotional honesty*.

They had their reasons for being there, though.

Wrong Hordak, effervescent as ever, looked over and winked. "Another successful session, my most exalted paramour!" he told Double Trouble proudly. "Now then, I must consult with Perfuma about the itinerary for next week's field trip to Mystacor. But *tonight*, I hope you are prepared to be dazzled by my famous quiche!" He beamed brightly.

Double Trouble worked very hard to maintain a calm expression while their stomach did acrobatic flip-flops. "My breath is *bated*, darling," they finally managed, before scurrying off to the other side of the room.

The thespian cursed, internally. It should *not* be this difficult for a shapeshifter to hide a blush.

Closer to the door, Hordak was showing Adora something on a data pad. Double Trouble wended a wide circle around them, even as Adora gasped in surprise and began babbling what certainly *seemed* like juicy gossip. They simply weren't in the mood.

Outside, Catra, Scorpia, and Entrapta were strolling away together, while the scorpion princess spoke excitedly about something called *'Super Pal Trio Game Night.'* Double Trouble pricked their ears — this, perhaps, was a more promising prospect for their problem.

They took a step forward, and were immediately interrupted.

"Where do you think *you're* going, hmm?"

Besides Perfuma, Wrong Hordak's other assistant for his therapy group was 'Skeletor,' one of Entrapta's eccentric bots. Once, he had been a part of Horde Prime's drone army. Now, he had a nasally voice, a talent for self improvement, and a puppy.

The puppy's name was Relay.

"How's this for a surprise?" Skeletor said, holding Relay and patting the robotic canine gently on the head. "I'm considering putting him on a leash!"

"That's very nice dear, but you'll have to excuse me," Double Trouble deflected. "I've got *issues* right now." They began to move past the skinny robot, before a thought occurred to them.

"Actually, you might be able to help me out with something. Tell me, how do you feel about aiding and abetting identity fraud? I'll make it worth your while."

"Mehehehehe! Just like the old days!" Skeletor cackled. "All right, you've got yourself a deal! What's your plan?"

Shadows Over Salineas was going swimmingly.

It wasn't really a game *night,* more of a game *afternoon*, but that hadn't stopped Scorpia from bringing a tower of boxes into Entrapta's Bright Moon lab. An entire world of cardboard and plastic was spread out before the three women.

"I am *going* to finish this Sword of Protection quest!" Catra angrily declared as she moved her game piece back and forth. "No matter *how* long it takes!"

"Okay, but the Evil Horde already has a lot of points at the Princess Alliance table," Entrapta cautioned, gesturing to another part of the board. "Plus they've got a *lot* of tanks in front of the castle."

"Anyone want to help me battle the Laughing Dragon?" Scorpia spoke up from behind a clawful of cards. "I'm gonna —"

She was cut short as the laboratory door suddenly opened and Skeletor slouched inside, wearing a miserable expression.

"This is the worst day of my *life!*" Skeletor moaned, flopping bodily across the table. Game pieces flew in every direction and clattered on the floor. The other three exchanged nervous glances.

Catra tossed her cards aside. “Well, I guess this is what we’re doing now. What’s the matter, boneface?”

“You’ve got to help me!” Skeletor blubbered. “When are you goody-goody fools going to understand? I care for no-one and no-one cares for me!” He shook his fists and produced a rose tied to a card covered in cartoony hearts.

Scorpia tilted her head. “Is that a flower?”

“It is a flower!” Skeletor howled. “The bitter rose! From a *secret admirer.*” He clutched it to his chest lovingly.

“Seriously?” Catra floundered. “Does somebody actually have a *crush* on that goof?”

“I know it sounds strange,” Skeletor retorted. “Never mind that!”

Entrapta rubbed her chin thoughtfully. “So, to be clear. You’re happy about getting the rose?”

“Yes, I am!” Skeletor shouted.

“But it’s a problem because…?”

“I live to be bad!” Skeletor whined. “How else can I act when I’m surrounded by such fools?” The robot swooned again. “*Nice?* Doesn’t sound like much fun to me! Yuck! What a disgusting idea!”

“Oh, I get it!” Entrapta grinned. “Skeletor needs us to teach him about love!”

Scorpia’s eyes sparkled. “A Super Pal Trio rescue mission? For *love?* I accept without any further questions!”

“Wait, wait,” Catra protested. “Stop. No. None of this makes *any* sense. Entrapta, is this another one of your secret friendship experiments?”

“Nuh-uh,” the scientist shook her head. “But... it is unexpected. Skeletor, are you *sure* you’re feeling all right?”

Skeletor looked uncomfortable. “Certainly! Um… *Tell me about the loneliness of good! Is it equal to the loneliness of evil?*”

Entrapta seemed suspicious. “Hang on,” she said, peering more closely at Skeletor. “Something isn’t quite right here.”

At that moment, Skeletor walked into the room, again. This time he was holding Relay and a fresh armload of barbarian romance novels.

“I can’t do it,” he admitted with an apologetic shrug, sheepishly handing back the books. “And, I do *not* look like you.”

“Oh phoo. I went too far, didn’t I?” the other Skeletor sighed, in a completely different voice. “I *knew* this wasn’t going to work.”

In a flash of dark light, Skeletor morphed into a decidedly more reptilian shape. Double Trouble huffed and tossed their hair back. “Well, that was *different*, at least. I’ve never done a robot before!” They paused. “Not in that sense, anyway.”

Catra started out of her chair. “What are *you* doing here?” she demanded.

“Just what I said.” Double Trouble sat back down on the table and nonchalantly studied their nails. “I need advice. *Romantic* advice. And since you three are all half of some of the oddest couples on the planet, I thought I might start here.”

“Okay,” Entrapta said, already beginning to take notes. “But you’ve come to me for that before. Why the disguise?”

Double Trouble looked away and muttered something.

“What was that?”

"I said it's because I was *embarrassed,* all right?" Double Trouble crossed their arms and pouted. "This is *not* something I usually need help with. *I'm* supposed to be the one who's cool and in control. I'm *Double Trouble!* But now I keep *feeling* things! In my mind, and my body! Making my guts act all weird, and my brain stop working, and… gah!"

"Those are called emotions, Dee Tee," Catra deadpanned.

"Plus, you and Wrong Hordak have been going steady for a while now," Scorpia added. "What's the matter? Oh no! Have you lost… *the spark?*" She gasped, claws to her face.

"Just the opposite. Wrongie is *perfect!* He's always in a good mood, he always wants to spend time with me, he always knows the right thing to say, and he's just so darn *cute!* All the time!" Double Trouble's face sank. "And sooner or later he's going to realize that I'm *not* perfect, and it's all just an act."

"You don't *have* to be perfect," Entrapta pointed out, looking up from her notes.

"This is *just* like what happens in *Romeo and Julian!*" Double Trouble wailed, ignoring her.

"What?" asked Skeletor.

Double Trouble sniffled. "It's a play. Someone in the Bright Moon army wrote it and it's been getting *rave* reviews in all the theatre magazines — oh, but that's not important! We're talking about *me!*" The lizard flailed their hands helplessly. "What I mean is, it's like we're from two different *worlds!*"

"What, Horde World and Etheria?" Scorpia guessed.

"I'm thinking more Innocent Baby World and Cynical Opportunist World," Catra cut in.

"Hey!" Double Trouble snapped. "I am *not* a cynic! Anymore!"

They turned to Scorpia. “But I can still make it work! I just need more *research.* Your girlfriend is all about this self-care nonsense. How do you *deal* with that?”

Scorpia got a dreamy look in her eyes. “Yeah, Perfuma’s pretty great. She’s kind, and patient with me, and she knows all *kinds* of meditation stuff, which is good because hey, funny story, it turns out I’ve actually got a *lot* of pent-up anxiety from —”

“Ugh! Useless! Next!” Double Trouble pointed to Entrapta. “You! *Space bats.* How do they even *work?*”

“Good question! I could share some of my research on Hordak with you,” Entrapta suggested. “It’s more of a hobby though, so I’ve only got a few terabytes of data. Did you know their species has an entire sub-language of ear movements? It’s fascinating!”

Double Trouble paled. “Um. Do you have an abridged version, or…?”

“Look,” Catra interrupted. “I think you’re coming at this the wrong way. First off, you can’t control what other people do or feel.”

Double Trouble narrowed their eyes. “That’s a bit rich coming from you, kitten.”

“I have been doing a *lot* of self-reflection the last few years, *okay?*” Catra growled back. “And trust me, trying to be the coolest, the strongest, the best? It doesn’t work.”

She looked across at Entrapta and Scorpia, and fiddled with the wedding ring on her finger. “Sooner or later you have to show your real self. Even if that’s uncomfortable. You can’t connect with someone that way until you’re willing to be weak in front of them.”

Double Trouble regarded Catra for a long time while their face registered a range of unreadable emotions.

"*Fine,*" they finally groaned, defeated. "But can you at *least* help me think of something nice to do for our dinner tonight?"

Catra smiled. Entrapta and Scorpia squeaked in excitement.

"For that, you'll need my help!" said Skeletor. "I've longed for this moment!"

Wrong Hordak looked up brightly from his cooking. "You are here! Come in, come in!" He swept Double Trouble up in an enormous hug.

The lizard blushed and did not try to hide it. "I wouldn't miss this for the world, darling." With a flourish they revealed a rose and a box of distinctively tiny chocolates, which Wrong Hordak accepted gleefully.

"Now then, why don't I stand back and let you impress me for a while?"

Wrong Hordak glowed with excitement.

"Impressive?" Skeletor said, somewhere far away. "You boob, it was *spectacular!*"

Chapter End Notes

> Double Trouble had everyone fooled until they accidentally quoted Skeletor from the live-action movie instead of the 80s cartoons.
>
> "Romeo and Julian" was written by General Juliet. It's a romantic comedy and everyone lives.
>
> Skeletor will return. Thank you for reading!

Secret of the Skeletor

Chapter Summary

> Skeletor sneaks out to visit some less-prominent former members of the Horde.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Skeletor sat alone in the laboratory.

He had strict orders not to go anywhere or do anything. As one of Horde Prime's drone bots, he knew the importance of rules. But ever since Entrapta had reprogrammed him with a name and a unique personality, he also knew the importance of *breaking* them.

Skeletor chuckled. He stood up, paused, then sat back down again and laughed some more as he pondered his options.

Just about everybody else in Bright Moon was busy. Even Wrong Hordak's usual support group was canceled while he attended the queen's cabinet meeting about Entrapta's new interdimensional research findings.

This meant it was the perfect time for Skeletor to venture outside the kingdom. A community outreach day. He grinned. Pausing only to giggle again and leash his beloved robot puppy, Relay, Skeletor snatched up Darla's ignition crystal and shambled out the door.

"Now for a little vanishing act!" he declared as he left.

It was going to be a *good* day.

Kyle braced himself as soon as he heard the ship engines come to a stop outside the window.

"Hey, guys?" he called to the other two inhabitants of their modest home. "I think —"

He was interrupted by the sound of splintering wood. "Strong, but not strong enough!" Skeletor yelled as he cheerfully kicked in the door. Rogelio, who had been going to open it, bristled in shock while Lonnie yelped and grabbed a frying pan from the kitchen, brandishing it like a club from behind the counter.

A long, stale moment passed.

"...It's all part of the game!" Skeletor explained apologetically, as he turned and tried to replace the door on its hinges. "We don't want to hurt anyone!" At his feet, Relay peered inside the room and barked, tail wagging.

All three of the former Horde soldiers relaxed and breathed a sigh of relief, though Lonnie's battle-ready expression did not change.

"Do you really have to do that *every* time you come over?" Kyle asked, poking at the loosely swinging door.

"Yes," Skeletor replied honestly.

Rogelio shrugged and growled something indistinct.

Lonnie quirked an eyebrow. "What? *You* asked him to come here?"

"We both did," Kyle piped up. He reached for Rogelio's hand in reassurance. "We… kinda wanted to get some more information on Wrong Hordak's support group."

Dutifully, Skeletor produced a sheaf of pamphlets and papers detailing schedules and services and handed them over to the two young men. Rogelio accepted them all with a brief roar of thanks.

Lonnie shook her head, still frowning. "Oh no. I already told you, I am *not* interested. Going over there for wellness day was one thing, but there are too many people there that I still just… can't be around. And he's nice and all, but I don't think Wrong Hordak really *gets* me."

"Running away. So impolite!" Skeletor scoffed.

"That's okay!" Kyle hastily added. "You don't have to come with us. We'd never force you into something like this."

"Running away sounds like a terrific idea!" Skeletor said.

Kyle looked at Rogelio. "It's just, we've been talking, and I think we want to give it a try. Even if it doesn't work out, we might be able to learn some stuff that could help. Taking the first step can be really hard, even when it's the right thing. And we'll be here if you decide you're ready, but we'll be here if you don't, too."

Lonnie's expression softened, slightly. "Thanks guys," she said, and meant it. She went to hug the other two. "Now, let's see about making this robot fix our door." She pounded a fist into her palm meaningfully.

"I think it's time for me to leave and take care of another matter!" Skeletor squeaked, and beat a hasty retreat.

Darla hovered serenely above the water on the Salinean coast. While Relay napped in the captain's chair, Skeletor strolled unhurriedly along the docks. He stopped in front of a small, shabby storefront and looked curiously at the sign above the door.

Sea Hawk's Ship Disposal and Firewood Emporium, it read. *You Crash 'Em, We Burn 'Em!*

"I think I'll make him my court jester, if he's funny enough!" Skeletor proclaimed, and walked inside.

However, it was instantly apparent from the lack of off-key sea shanties being sung that the shop's namesake proprietor was currently absent. This suited the skinny robot just fine. The real subject of his visit was the new part-time hire, who sat slouched at the register behind a gossip-scroll and an eyepatch.

Octavia brightened when she saw Skeletor enter. "Hey, I was wondering when you'd make it back here!" she called out. Skeletor waved in response and marched over, holding out a laden bag.

"Special delivery!" Skeletor announced.

Octavia's good eye shone as she reached inside and pulled out a glittering, silver fishing net. "Oh, wow, Entrapta finished it already!" she gushed, holding the netting up to the light to admire it.

"That net is made of elastium!" Skeletor boasted. "It's not only one of the hardest substances in the universe, it also stretches!"

"Hey, thanks for helping me commission this," Octavia said, looking back. She smiled wistfully. "Entrapta really was the best part of the Horde when we were all there, you know? She was so nice to everyone, and Hordak was loads calmer, and all our maintenance complaints got fixed practically overnight!"

"That's just peachy for you!" Skeletor said.

"Plus, it kinda took some of the sting out of having to take orders from the kid who did *this* when we were six," Octavia added, gesturing to her eyepatch. "I had ambitions, you know? I was the first of our class to make Force Captain. I was going places! Of course, none of that matters anymore."

Her sour expression melted as she looked back at the new net. "But that won't stop me! With this I can make some extra money on the side selling seafood. Then I'll buy this place from Sea Hawk — honestly, I think he forgets he owns it sometimes — and turn it into a crafting and antique shop, *Octopus Cove* or *Mystic Isle* or

something. After that I'll take over all the shops on the dock one by one, and then the beach tourism market will be *mine!* Ha ha!"

She cackled with evil glee. Skeletor joined in, politely.

"Too bad about the others, but at least I escaped!" Skeletor concluded, and left to continue his mission.

"Beast-Man!" Skeletor sang as the door opened.

"I still don't know who that is, but it's good to see you again too," Grizzlor grinned. "Come on in, buddy!"

Skeletor followed the wolffish giant inside while Relay trotted happily at his heels. Grizzlor's husband, fellow former Horde Commander Cobalt, was relaxing in their living room and waved when he saw the bot.

"Skeletor! How've you been?"

"Sitting down on the job?" Skeletor barked. "I'll help you, if only to be rid of you!" He offered Cobalt a thick folder of paperwork. "Here, here it is!"

Cobalt accepted the folder reverentially. "Really? I knew it was a long shot asking Hordak for help, but all the red tape was getting to be such a nightmare that I just didn't know what to do anymore." He sniffled and wiped a tear from his eye. "Thank you so much!"

"You're crying for Hordak?" Skeletor huffed. "I don't believe it!"

"I can't believe that worked," Grizzlor admitted. "I mean, I always thought Hordak hated me," he added sheepishly. "*Especially* after that thing with the two neckties."

Cobalt shook his head. "Nah, I don't think Hordak ever really *hated* anybody. He just didn't know what to *do* with anyone. Now, Shadow Weaver on the other hand…"

“Most unpleasant!” Skeletor muttered.

“Exactly. But I think Hordak *did* care, in his own way. He saw how scared we were of combat during the early days, in the Scorpion uprising. I think that’s why he kept me teaching the cadets and you on the easy patrols, Grizz.”

Grizzlor chuckled. “Aw, I can’t imagine you being scared of *anything*, big guy!”

“Oh, I wasn’t always like this!” Cobalt demurred, flexing his shoulders. “Back in my cadet days I was so skinny everyone called me ‘Mantenna’! Used to joke that I’d fall through a crack in the floor if I wasn’t careful.”

“Another piece of the puzzle!” said Skeletor.

Cobalt slung an arm around Grizzlor. “But listen, Horde or no, I’ll always be there for you.” He held up the adoption papers Skeletor had delivered. “And now, we might have something else to protect together.”

Skeletor’s last stop was a recently-refurbished tavern just inside the Crimson Waste. He nodded approvingly at the osseous architecture and then pushed his way through the curtain while Relay ran ahead, yapping.

Inside there was a wide, smoky space filled with outlaws and ruffians of every species imaginable. They all turned to look as Skeletor entered.

“That’s it! Kneel before your new master!” Skeletor bellowed.

Everyone immediately went back to what they had been doing. The chatter and plinky piano music returned. Relay found a small lizard and began to chase it around the floor.

“Skeletor! It’s good to see you back, friend!”

An enormous purple hand clapped the robot on the shoulder. Skeletor looked up into the smiling face of a towering barbarian.

“Can I get you anything?” Huntara asked, conversationally. “Minions to yell at? A ribcage chair to sit in?”

“Unnecessary! Because we’ve already found you!” Skeletor replied.

“Good, I was hoping you’d say that. Zed! Sunder!” Huntara called out. Two Horde clones who were staffing the bar — one seeming slightly shorter than the typical clone brother, and the other a bit older and wrinklier — glanced up at the sound of their names and hurried over.

“Keep an eye on the door, willya? I need to talk to bonehead here for a bit. We’ve got… *business* to discuss.”

The two clones nodded seriously, and Huntara escorted Skeletor to a secretive back room behind the bar. Inside there were many potted cacti, two comfortable chairs, and a little table with a miniature sand garden on top. It had a tiny, handheld rake for making soothing patterns in the sand.

“I’m so glad you’re here!” Huntara sighed in relief, dropping into one of the chairs. Relay jumped into her lap and she patted his head gratefully. “I have so much to talk about! You know how last time I was telling you about Grox and all the things she was saying to me? *Well…*”

“Easy, don’t overexert yourself! It’ll only cause you to weaken more quickly,” Skeletor cautioned. He settled into the other chair and leaned forward, listening intently.

“Yeah, I know. It’s just nice to have someone to talk to, Huntara said. “I don’t feel comfortable in big groups and I can’t always open up to the people around here. So thanks for stopping by.”

Skeletor nodded. “I’m right here, old friend! Release the shadow beast!”

A weight seemed to leave Huntara's shoulders. "All right. Now, like I was saying…"

Long after the stars had come out, the laboratory door finally swung open again. Entrapta and Hordak, looking exhausted but accomplished, strode inside with their arms full of rolled-up diagrams and data sheets from that day's presentation.

"...And they listened to *everything* I said!" Entrapta exclaimed as they came in. "I can't *remember* the last time anybody besides you paid attention to me for that long. It was kinda scary, but it felt kinda good, too!"

"They were fools if they never attended to you before," Hordak purred, smiling proudly. "And I cannot imagine they would disregard you now. After all, you are talking about the prospect of rescuing —"

"Sounds like we've got company!" Skeletor interrupted, welcoming the couple back to the lab. He was sitting, hands primly folded, in exactly the same spot as he had been when they left. "I've been expecting you!"

"Oh. Hello, Skeletor," Hordak sighed, reluctantly looking away from Entrapta. "Did you follow my instructions to stay put today?"

Skeletor crossed his fingers and nodded.

"Did you follow *my* instructions?" Entrapta whispered, after Hordak had gone on ahead. Skeletor nodded again, much more enthusiastically this time.

"Good robot!" Entrapta replied, with a wink and a smile. "Thanks for helping out!" Then she scampered away to keep up with her lab partner.

"Ha! My plan has worked perfectly!" Skeletor gloated. "Now *I* have the power!"

Chapter End Notes

There are a lot of 80s references in this one! :p

I wonder what that big meeting was all about?

For Want of a Skeletor

Chapter Summary

> Entrapta hosts a Princess Alliance meeting at the Crypto Castle and absolutely nothing goes wrong.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The lights were on late in Dryl.

Stars shone outside the windows. Entrapta sat hunched over her desk, studying datapads and readouts. A polite cough from the laboratory door caused her to look up from her work.

"Oh! I'm sorry Hordak, did I wake you?"

Her partner stepped softly into the room and shook his head. "Imp did. You know how he gets when either of us take too long to come to bed."

Hordak crossed the cluttered floor and joined Entrapta at the desk. He was holding Imp in his arms, and the smaller, winged clone whined plaintively when he saw her. Entrapta kept her screens on, but leaned gratefully into Hordak's side and curled a tendril of hair around his waist. She yawned, despite herself.

"I know. I just want to make sure I get everything right before the other princesses come over tomorrow." She glanced back at the data, nervously tapping her fingertips together. "I've never hosted an Alliance meeting before! And this rescue will be our biggest mission since… well, you know. I don't want to mess anything up."

Hordak smiled. "Your diligence is admirable. But I also seem to recall someone telling me that imperfections are beautiful."

Entrapta stuck out her tongue. "No fair."

“I’m afraid the science is sound. Come to bed, my dear.”

The scientist scoffed, but she did not protest when Hordak gathered her up in his arms. She wrapped more of her hair around him, and Imp settled sleepily in the resulting nest. Entrapta could already feel herself drifting.

“You will be a shining star tomorrow,” Hordak promised, as he carried his family back to rest.

“Tomorrow,” echoed Imp.

The next day saw the Crypto Castle’s largest meeting room filled with princesses, dignitaries, and other honorary Alliance members. While Scorpia and Perfuma admired the tiny refreshments laid out for everyone, Mermista split her time between groaning at Sea Hawk’s boasts and trying every available chair to find the most comfortable one. Glimmer and Bow stepped uneasily around the edges of the room, watching carefully for anything that might be a trap, and Frosta followed their lead. Netossa and Spinnerella tried their best to find a chair Swift Wind could sit in.

Adora and Catra, wearing increasingly baffled expressions, were conversing with two domestic-looking robots who sat at the head of the table next to Entrapta. One was tall and skinny, and the other wore a welded-on handlebar mustache.

“Entrapta has *parents?*” Catra was asking, her face a galaxy of disbelief.

“Adopted, technically. Or adapted,” the skinnier bot explained. “We’re Entrapta’s parental units. She built us when she was six. You must have seen the painting in the foyer.”

“Yeah, we’ve been here pretty much the whole time,” the mustachioed model added. “You kids sure made a racket during your last few visits. What was that all about?”

“Uh,” Adora faltered.

To her immense relief, Hordak swept into the room at that very moment, flanked by Imp, Emily, and the reprogrammed Horde drone Entrapta had dubbed 'Skeletor.'

"Welcome, everyone," Hordak boomed, bringing the gathering to a respectful hush.

"Witless fools! I'm in charge now! And if you know what's good for you you'll do as I say!" Skeletor shouted.

Hordak scowled and shooed the fussing robot away from the table. "Pay no mind to that one," he grumbled once he'd regained the floor. "Now then. Please allow me the honor of introducing the unparalleled mind who has made this operation possible, Princess Entrapta."

"Thank you all for coming!" Entrapta started, while everyone took their seats. "I know you're all excited about what we're planning, but there's still a lot of preparation to do before we can take off. As the chief science officers for this mission, it's vital that Hordak and I gather as much data on your abilities as possible! Interdimensional travel is *severely* unpredictable and —"

"Hold on," Mermista interrupted. "Exactly *how high* are the chances of us getting mutated by cosmic space energy or whatever? Because I only want cool mutations, not gross ones."

"Maybe thirty, thirty-five percent?" Entrapta guessed. She shrugged. "A lot of this is theoretical. You guys will be like my guinea pigs! By which I mean the small robotic animals in the castle I protect and care for. And experiment on, sometimes."

She laughed heartily. Glimmer and Bow shared a nervous glance. Perfuma turned slightly green.

Entrapta regained her composure and pointed back to the display board. "Ahem. Anyway, the *good* news is we already know some things about where we're going! Probably." She shuffled her notes, gaining confidence as she spoke.

"Before Adora found the Sword of Protection, historians debated ancient records of She-Ra. Some claimed she was called '*Her-Ra*' and fought for the '*Power of Grayskull*.' But *I* theorize that what those archaeologists *actually* uncovered was evidence of —"

"I have a question!" Frosta yelled. "Will there be hunky guys in the other dimension? I'm asking for a friend."

"It's funny you mention that, actually," Entrapta replied. "Listen, just let me finish and…"

Unfortunately, anxious impatience had already gripped the assembled Alliance members. They clamored with questions, all talking at the same time. Entrapta shrank back in her seat and pulled her welding mask down, seeming to reach for something under the table.

Hordak stood up. Just as it looked like he was about to do something violent, a loud alarm sounded and the lights in the room flashed red.

"Uh-oh." Entrapta glanced around at the assembled company. "Um, get ready to tuck and roll everybody!"

"Get ready to *what?*" Mermista cried out, but it was already too late. Multiple trap doors swung open across the meeting room floor, and with flailing limbs and startled shouts the guests were sent tumbling down chutes in every direction. In moments they had all vanished.

"I always feel so much better after doing something bad!" Skeletor cackled. "Now we begin phase two!"

Adora and Catra, who had clung to each other as they fell, landed with a bump in a darkened, underground space. As soon as they arrived, bright lights flickered to life and a huge screen lit up against the wall.

Entrapta's face appeared on the monitor, larger than life. "Oh good! You're alive," she chirped when she saw the other two.

Adora clambered to her feet. "Entrapta! What's going on?"

The scientist glanced away. "Well, I guess Skeletor didn't like that we were ignoring him. So he stole my map of the castle and activated the security systems! Which means we're all lost in the labyrinth until I can catch him. Isn't that great?"

"It's something," Catra groaned, rubbing her head.

"Exactly! Now, without my map I can't come find you. But if you can make it through the traps, the hallway you're in should take you back to the meeting room. Then you'll be safe until I can fix things!"

The screen dimmed again before Catra or Adora could protest. Left with few other options, they turned to get a good look at whatever dangers lay ahead.

They were standing at one end of a long corridor. Square blocks floated along its length, suspended in midair with anti-gravitational tech. An interrogative punctuation mark flashed on one, while a squat robot with painted-on angry eyebrows shambled slowly back and forth beneath it.

Catra took it all in. "You have *got* to be kidding."

Adora had already drawn her sword and begun to venture forward. Catra was about to follow her, when something made her ears flick. A suspicious frown crossed her face.

"Hey, Adora!" Catra called. "Listen!"

"What?"

Catra pressed her ear to the wall. "There! Do you hear that?"

“Obviously not,” Adora huffed. “Now stop dawdling, the first puzzle looks pretty easy.”

Catra stayed where she was. “Hold on a second. This part of the castle feels familiar. I remember walking through here back when, uh, back when it was still Horde territory.” She coughed awkwardly, and then reached up to tilt the frame of a big-eyed kitten painting. “Look!”

Something clicked and the wall slid open, revealing a new passageway. Distinctive laughter could be heard coming from the other end of it. A purple neon sign reading “Secret Entrance!!!” buzzed to life.

Adora sighed and rolled her eyes.

“One time Entrapta had me and Scorpia over for a life-size *Snakemen and Ladders* game that got a little out of hand,” Catra explained as they entered the tunnel. At the far end there was a brightly lit office; inside, it was filled with laboratory equipment, video monitors, and a humble but dignified desk.

Hordak was sitting at the desk, in what appeared to be a smaller version of his old Fright Zone throne. It swiveled. Entrapta was sitting on the desk, and she waved as the other couple entered.

“Myaah! Sleep gas and stun-rays only, my evil minions!” muttered Skeletor, who was busy working the video monitors. On closer inspection, Adora realized that each of them showed some of the other princesses as they traversed the castle labyrinth.

“Welcome to mission control!” Entrapta sang, spreading her arms wide. “Hordak didn’t think you’d find us, but I had a hypothesis you might.”

“It was a ruse!” Adora gasped, scandalized. “You’re not lost at all!”

“You really need to hang out with Entrapta more if that still surprises you,” Catra observed. She looked at the monitors. “Ah,

are they gonna be okay?”

“Better than!” Entrapta sprang off the desk, hanging by her hair as she showed off multiple datapads. “Everyone was getting a little… *distracted* upstairs, so I just decided to speed things up a teensy bit! The princesses using their powers to escape the maze will let me get all the readings we need, and then we can have a nice little party! I had the baker make tiny cakes.”

“I made sure Hordak’s doomberry pie was especially tasty!” Skeletor piped up.

“And it’s all perfectly safe!” Entrapta promised. Discreetly, a ribbon of hair reached out to push a blinking button. On the monitors, Mermista and Sea Hawk were rescued from a robot shark attack by a convenient change of the currents.

“This is hilarious,” Catra laughed, looking more closely. On one of the screens, Swift Wind was gleefully running loop-de-loops along a curving racetrack. “I think they’re actually having fun in there. Can we stay and watch?”

“I’m afraid not,” Hordak said. She-Ra’s — and your — assessment is the most important of all. But we’d love to have you over to the castle for dinner soon. Shall we say eight o’clock next week?”

“That sounds nice!” Adora chimed, before Catra could stop her.

“Splendid. I’ll cook,” Hordak concluded. Then he pressed a button on his desk, and a trapdoor sent the younger women plummeting through the floor.

Catra and Adora yelped in surprise, only for their fall to be cut short by an enormous pile of pillows on the level below. They struggled to their feet. Another corridor stretched away in front of them, filled with further challenges. Floating gold coins, each about four feet tall, indicated a pathway.

“Try not to have too much fun,” Hordak called good-naturedly as the trapdoor slid shut.

“Use the warp zone! It’s faster!” Entrapta added.

“Have a nice trip down!” said Skeletor.

Hordak settled back in his chair (it had soft armrests, and a cushion for lumbar support) and watched his partner at work. Entrapta flitted from screen to screen, taking notes and making adjustments. On one display, Bow and Glimmer had met up with Netossa and Spinnerella while navigating a cage minefield. On another, Frosta was making an ice bridge to help Perfuma and Scorpia cross a slow-moving spike trap.

“I’m sorry you had to use your backup plan. They really are utter fools if they ever doubted your genius,” Hordak mused.

“Different people have different strengths and weaknesses,” Entrapta replied, without looking up from her work. “And a good scientist collaborates whenever they can! Even if that requires a little creativity sometimes.”

Hordak nodded. “Fair enough. Nevertheless, I would not blame you if you wished to have nothing more to do with the Princess Alliance. Even their attempts to help you can seem… insensitive. You’re not obligated to forgive that.”

Skeletor looked up from his control panel and shook a fist. “Don’t you get awfully tired of being a hero all the time? Don’t you ever feel like doing something *evil?*”

“They’re trying to be good friends,” Entrapta defended. “And so am I. And if I really did need their help, maybe things would be different. But I’ve got it all under control!”

She vaulted across the room, flipping switches and turning dials along the way. On the monitors, Perfuma’s fall from a tall platform was gently broken by a sudden anti-gravitational field.

“Besides, forgiveness isn’t always about the person being forgiven. It’s also about taking back potential energy that was

lost."

"Did you learn that in my brother's therapy group?" Hordak asked.

Entrapta smirked. "Actually, he got it from me."

A pleasant *ding* sounded and Entrapta clapped her hair. "Hooray, everyone made it back! I'll calculate the high scores and then we can continue the social experiment!"

"You astonish me every day," Hordak purred as he rose to follow her. Entrapta put out her hand, and he took it.

"Wait for me!" Skeletor cried out. "You might get lost by yourself!"

One week later, a much smaller gathering of royals met in Dryl.

Catra and Adora sat together in one of the Crypto Castle's least intimidating dining rooms, listening with barely-contained delight as Entrapta's parental units thoroughly embarrassed their former boss.

"...And so I said to him, 'I have charging ports Hordak, can you download raw data offa *me?*' Ha! Oh, you shoulda *seen* his face!"

Hordak slouched in his chair. "I do not think we need to bore our guests with the details of this particular story," he protested, feebly.

"Oh, I'm not bored at all! I want to hear *everything*," Catra said. She leaned forward, grinning. "So, was this before or after you hooked him up to the lie detector?"

Entrapta giggled, and gave Hordak a gentle pat on the shoulder as she reached for another helping of his tiny quiche. All things considered, the night was going surprisingly well.

It was exactly what Entrapta wanted.

After dinner, wheeled bots carted away the leftovers and dirty dishes. Hordak poured coffee for himself and Adora, and the parental units retired to wherever it was they lived in the cavernous castle. Entrapta, lost in thought as usual, felt a familiar feline presence approach her.

"Thank you," Catra said, sincerely. "Not just for this. For everything. For being so *nice* all the time. For making this mission happen. It means a lot to me."

Entrapta smiled softly. "To me, too. Everyone makes mistakes. It would be a shame not to learn from them when we can."

"Did you say something?" Skeletor squawked, suddenly materializing in the doorway.

Entrapta, unbothered, immediately produced a datapad. "Oh we're just talking about the big rescue mission! Actually, you should probably take a look at my data, Skeletor. I haven't told you much yet, and we might need you!" She held the blinking screen out happily.

Skeletor looked at the datapad. At first he seemed confused; then he boggled as he registered the information in front of him. "Eternia?" he gasped in disbelief. "*Grayskull?*"

His voice rose to a fevered pitch. "*He-Man!*"

For once, Skeletor had no words. He shrieked incomprehensibly instead, fists shaking.

Hordak chuckled. "It'll be just like the old days!"

Skeletor screamed.

Chapter End Notes

To be continued!

Thank you so much for reading. Your comments make me happier than you could possibly imagine.

Skeletor Ain't Heavy

Chapter Summary

> Two brothers seek out a community, and Wrong Hordak reflects on his past.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Two brothers walked the hallways of Bright Moon palace. They were Horde clones, cautious, curious, and concerned.

"Are you sure this is the right way? I'm certain we passed that decorative waterfall twice already," the shorter clone complained. He had swept-back ears, and two extra eyes that would never open.

"Don't be rude," the other chided. Tired wrinkles hung at the corners of his eyes and mouth, but he shared the same chestnut shade of hair as his brother.

"Not only do you trespass in my domain, but you insult me as well! I know the way, I've been there before," squawked the gangly robot guiding them. He strutted purposefully ahead before halting at an arched entryway. "Ha! Here it is! Now, with this magic spell, we shall open a gateway to an evil, little-known dimension!"

He knocked on the door. It swung open.

Wrong Hordak stood on the other side, bouncing on his feet and wearing an effervescent grin. "Hello, Skeletor!" he said to the robot. "And welcome, brothers! Please, come in!"

The exuberant clone stepped aside and beckoned the other two through the door. They followed, and found themselves in a modest space filled with a number of other Horde clones. The

flock milled comfortably about the room, striking up conversations, taking fruit slices and coffee from a table in the back, and gradually getting settled around an open ring of chairs.

“Is it your first time here?” Wrong Hordak asked.

The older clone nodded. “Yes. I am named Sunder, and this is Zed. Skeletor told us about your support group for former members of the Horde. May we join you?”

“Of course!” Wrong Hordak beamed and motioned for the newcomers to join the circle. As they did so, the only other person in the room who wasn’t a clone — a prim-looking lizard — quirked an eyebrow in Skeletor’s direction.

Double Trouble, a plate of honeydew in hand, sauntered over to where Wrong Hordak stood. “I thought Skeletor left with the princesses on that big interdimensional field trip?” they whispered, bemused.

“Oh, he couldn’t find a pet sitter for Relay,” Wrong Hordak replied, gesturing to a small robotic puppy sitting happily on a pillow in the corner. Skeletor gathered it up lovingly and almost seemed to smile.

“Stop licking my face, you dratted dog!” Skeletor whined as Relay greeted him enthusiastically. “Gah! You’re drowning me!”

He made no motion to put the mechanical mutt down.

“What? But that doesn’t… oh, never mind.” Double Trouble sighed and wrapped themself around Wrong Hordak’s arm. “In that case, darling, we may as well get started. I want to hear from the fresh meat!”

They joined the group. Wrong Hordak gave a short clap to bring the session to order, and the ring of clones hushed. They watched him expectantly.

“Welcome, everyone!” Wrong Hordak began. “Thank you for coming. Today we are joined by two new friends. Brothers, are you willing to share your stories with us?”

Zed nodded. “We’ve been living in the Crimson Waste since the end of the war, under Huntara’s protection. We were both on the *Velvet Glove* when it became, ah…”

“The Space Tree,” one of the other clones supplied.

“…The Space Tree, thank you. I am — was — being grown as Horde Prime’s next holy vessel. But I decanted prematurely when he was defeated by She-Ra.” Zed looked guiltily away from the others. “I have never known a world without freedom from Prime. Yet his evil will always mark me.”

“Whereas I,” Sunder continued, “served the Galactic Horde for many years, and committed many atrocities in Prime’s name. There was even a time when I imagined myself his top general, though I have since learned that this was a lie he told to many of us.”

Several of the clones nodded sympathetically.

Sunder touched the wrinkles on his face. “But even we clones grow old. I was scheduled to be decommissioned, until Prime fell and awakening came upon us all. His death granted me new life.”

“Hello, Sunder!” the group greeted in cheerful unison. “Hello, Zed!”

“Thank you for sharing, brothers,” Wrong Hordak commended. “Is there anything you wish to ask of us?”

Sunder shifted uncomfortably in his seat. “There is. I came here because I want to know… how can I live with what I have done? How do any of us atone for the pain we caused under Prime’s control? We’ve worked as hard to heal the planet as anyone, but is it enough?”

“And how can we be sure never to harm anyone else?” Zed cut in. “How do I know I will not make the same mistakes that created Prime?”

“My goodness! Such pathos,” muttered Double Trouble, not unkindly.

“I also have this fear,” one of the clones volunteered. “My sleep cycle is often interrupted by unpleasant fantasies. I imagine myself saying, ‘If Horde Prime created me in hatred, am I not doomed to hate?’”

Wrong Hordak nodded in understanding. “It is not shameful to have such thoughts. And I also know what it is like to have memories that… no longer give me pride.” He narrowed his eyes. “I served Horde Prime in many battles on many planets before I met the liberator Entrapta and her friends. Regretfully, I can remember most of them.”

“Yes, I have such memories too,” said Sunder. “Sometimes I wish they could still be taken away from me, but I know that is not the way.” The old clone had an earnest expression. “Please, what rituals may I perform to calm the storm inside my mind?”

“I have found that nothing works for every one of us without error,” Wrong Hordak replied, glancing around at the gathered individuals. “Yet for many of us it is beneficial to think of choosing love instead of hatred. It is not an easy task, of course, but it is still our greatest power, to *choose* .”

“You are who you choose to be,” Double Trouble stated sagely, their features flickering for a few moments.

“As for my memories,” Wrong Hordak went on. He took a deep breath, as if he had been pondering what he was about to say next for a long time.

“Looking back, I find most of my life acceptable and good — and most of it I wouldn’t change. I can see the surprise in your face! But yes, I would choose the same progenitors, the same siblings,

whatever their flaws or mistakes. I would fall in love with the same person and plan the same future."

He shared a warm look with Double Trouble. "So the regrets — and there *are* many of them — are not a rejection of fate. They are essentially hindsight. *If* I know them."

Wrong Hordak spoke the *if* with conviction.

"Now certainly, if I had just been decanted, knowing what I know now, I would have behaved differently. I might imagine that I should have done this, could have become that, and my life would have been richer, more governed by love and concern for others, more full of life, spirit, humor, adventure, experimentation, risk-taking."

He gave Double Trouble another knowing glance. "However, in those moments I am looking at my life as the director of a play might look at the script. They might say 'cut that awful scene' or 'have him act more compassionately.' But they are the *director* . They know the end of the story! Whereas I, an actor, had to grope along, trying to find the right way, and trying to find the courage to do what I should have done."

Wrong Hordak sighed. "So now, I suppose I have to forgive myself for being a messy infant. For being afraid of bullies, for not understanding others, for wasting time, for feeling negative and discouraged, for not expressing love more effectively, for not opening myself to the experience of what others were willing to give me."

Zed and Sunder were leaning forward, listening intently. Nevertheless, something in their expressions still seemed uncertain.

"I don't understand," the older clone ventured. "Wouldn't you still change the past *if* you could?"

"And how do you know what to do now?" Zed added.

“I don’t,” Wrong Hordak shrugged. “I have imagined, if there were an all-powerful being, and they told me, ‘Very well, I shall grant you another try,' and if I lived the same life over, only better, what would happen? At the end, would I feel satisfied? Proud?”

“Yes?” Sunder tried.

“Maybe?” Zed guessed.

“I would not,” Wrong Hordak replied, gently. “Because there would still be an entire *universe* of variables! As a result of the experience of the second attempt I would only cry out, ‘I’ve failed again! Now, as a result of the second attempt, I clearly see how it *should* have gone! Oh please, let me stay for one more try!’”

Sunder contemplated this. “And how would your hypothetical omnipotent being respond?”

“They would say, ‘It is no use, Wrong Hordak. Nothing can be perfect. The third attempt would only bring an increase in wisdom and a completely new set of regrets.’”

Zed and Sunder sat back as they took this in. Then they looked at each other, and seemed to reach an unspoken agreement.

“I believe we have much to discuss,” Sunder said eventually.

“Do you meet at the same time every week?” Zed asked.

Wrong Hordak smiled.

Later, after the group had concluded their meeting and most of the attendees had left, Wrong Hordak paused thoughtfully while he stacked the chairs and cleaned up the space.

“Witless fools, do I have to do everything for you?” Skeletor muttered, passing by with the mop.

Double Trouble noticed and approached their clone lover. “That was a lovely speech you gave today,” they said. “Would you really not change anything in your life?”

“There are many things I might have done differently,” Wrong Hordak admitted. “But if the events of my existence had not transpired *exactly* as they did, I would not be where I am now. And I like where I am now very much.”

“Bravo,” Double Trouble applauded.

They embraced.

“Hmph! That’s your opinion,” Skeletor grouched. “I don’t do things for humanity, I do them for me!” He shook his head. “Oh, *why* do I surround myself with fools? Even the robots are smarter than you!”

Chapter End Notes

> Wrong Hordak's big speech is taken almost verbatim from a letter written by one of my parent's mentors. I think about it a lot.
>
> Zed and Sunder are named after Prince Zed and General Sunder, two minor Horde characters from the 80s cartoon.
>
> Thank you for reading!

Return of the Skeletor

Chapter Summary

A family reunion.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Micah remembered the other world.

Most people could, in fact. The whole planet was affected. They'd all lived a life they thought was perfect. They'd all imagined something intangible. The memories were faded and fragmentary, like the recollection of a dream, but everyone was certain it had really happened.

Even if nothing that had happened was real.

At first Micah didn't realize anyone else had shared in the dream. He'd lost track of time on Beast Island long ago, and when the collapsing portal closed around him he only assumed it was one of the despairing wasteland's many tricks. He never had long to dwell on the matter, either. Soon after finding himself returned to reality (he could remember shouting to Angella, reaching for her, trying to tell her "I'm not *dead!*") Micah had met the loud and unusual Princess Entrapta. And after *her* there came…

"She-Ra! It's She-Ra!" a nasally voice shrieked.

Micah was startled out of his reverie by a sudden clattering of hooves. The door to his Bright Moon office burst inwards and he was presented with the sight of a breathless Swift Wind. Sitting astride the rainbow-winged unicorn was one of Entrapta's bots, a lanky drone she'd named 'Skeletor.'

"The time has come!" Skeletor said.

"It's true!" Swift Wind confirmed. "I felt the sacred bond return just a minute ago. Adora and the others are back from Eternia! Darla is over the Whispering Woods *right now!*"

"What?" Micah jumped to his feet, abandoning his desk without a second thought. It was covered in a mountain of paperwork: royal records, his regent's duties, and the calendar pages where he'd marked off every day since Glimmer and the rest of the Princess Alliance left for their dangerous mission to another universe. He rushed to the door where Swift Wind was standing.

Skeletor reached out and helped Micah onto the horse's back. "Join hands as we bring together our mystic powers!" the robot cried. Once Micah was settled, Swift Wind turned and leapt out the nearest window. They sailed through the skies.

"What's going on? Are they all right?" Micah asked, with undisguised worry.

Swift Wind banked, soaring over the tree line. "I'm not sure! The ship is under control but — look, there it is!"

Darla, the rebuilt First Ones ship, was descending rapidly from the sky over the treetops. Her flight was steady, but parts of the hull were damaged, and smoke trailed from one wing. Suddenly the ship lurched and plummeted into the trees, vanishing from sight. A plume of vegetation went flying as it plowed to a smoldering stop.

Micah felt his stomach twist. "We need to get closer!" he called out in a panic.

"I can take you there!" Skeletor declared, urging Swift Wind toward the ground. They touched down by the edge of a long path of smoking destruction that stretched deep into the woods.

"They must have landed near here," Skeletor deduced, observing the massive trench in the ground. He hopped off the horse's back and ran ahead, making anxious utterances as he went.

Micah dismounted and walked beside Swift Wind. "I hate this," Micah confessed. "The staying behind, I mean. At least on Beast Island I was the only one I had to worry about, and I was in control of my own survival. But having to stand by while Glimmer goes into danger? I'm so proud of her, yet I'm also so scared."

"I know what you mean," Swift Wind answered. "I trust Adora, but I also worry about her, like, *all* the time. Whenever we're apart I get so restless. I just feel powerless!"

"Sometimes letting them find their own way is all we can do," Micah mused.

They came into a clearing in the woods. Darla was there, sparking and steaming but generally intact. Skeletor hammered on the door.

"Here, let me try to get you out!" he called.

Something inside the ship made a noise. There was a hiss and a jet of steam, and Skeletor tumbled backwards, landing with a squawk at Micah and Swift Wind's feet. They all stared at Darla, holding their breath expectantly.

The front hatch of the spaceship popped open. Entrapta erupted out of it, tumbling down the landing ramp in a ball of frizzled hair. She pulled her goggles up.

"Aha! We made it!" she crowed, taking in her surroundings. "All in the right dimension and everything!"

She reached into the recesses of her hair and emerged with a haggard Hordak. "Your piloting saved us! I knew you could do it!" she told him proudly.

Hordak squinted through half-lidded eyes. "Is it over?" he muttered. "Are we still alive?"

"Yep!" Entrapta wobbled to her feet and gathered her partner up in her ponytails. "Now, let's get you a checkup and some rest.

You've had a stressful voyage!"

She suddenly seemed to notice the gathered onlookers. "Oh! Hi Skeletor. Hi Bird Horse. Hi Micah. Guess what? You're gonna *love* this!" Entrapta turned back to the ship. "Safe to disembark, crew!" she yelled, before trotting off with Hordak.

"Now we'll see how clever you are!" Skeletor said.

Mermista peeked around the door. "Ground!" she cried, throwing herself across the dirt in relief. "I never thought I'd miss you so much!"

"Oh, it wasn't *that* bad a flight," Sea Hawk cajoled, helping her to her feet. "Why, I can think of a dozen — no, *two* dozen more harrowing trips I've taken in the *Dragon's Daughter XXVIII*."

"You fishmonger," Skeletor scoffed.

Frosta was the next one out, followed closely by Perfuma and Scorpia. "Eternia was amazing!" the teenaged ice princess announced, brandishing a pair of frozen fists. "I got to punch *so much* stuff!"

"Come on, it wasn't *all* violence," Perfuma pleaded.

"Yeah, we learned a bunch about friendship and responsibility too," Scorpia agreed.

"Punch! Punch!" Frosta said.

"You're becoming evil, I can sense it!" Skeletor hummed approvingly. "Excellent!"

Catra and Adora came next, and they were accompanied by a young man Micah had never seen before. He had a pink shirt, bobbed blond hair, and bore an uncanny resemblance to Adora herself. A sword hung on his back. He blinked as he emerged into the light.

Swift Wind's jaw dropped. "Adora! Is that…?"

"Hey guys!" Adora grinned sheepishly. "So, funny story. You remember how when I was a baby I was taken from a hidden First Ones faction that nobody has ever been able to find since?"

She held her hands out, presenting the newcomer. "Well, uh, we found 'em! This is my twin brother, Adam!"

Adam smiled and waved. "Hello everybody," he chirped.

"Brother?" Swift Wind sputtered.

"*He-Man!*" Skeletor bellowed.

The group fell into a chattering commotion, but Micah was hardly paying attention. Glimmer and Bow had appeared at the top of the ramp, holding each other as they looked out. Emotions that went beyond words swam in the young queen's eyes.

Adora saw where Micah was looking and quickly pulled her brother away. "We'll tell you the whole story later, sir! Trust me, it's hilarious. Now come on, I gotta show you around Etheria, *bro*."

"Sure thing, *sis*," Adam replied, grinning hugely. They pounded their fists together, adding their own sound effects as they did so, and marched off laughing.

"They have been doing that the *entire*. Trip. Back," Catra groaned, following close behind the pair. "Somebody *save* me."

"You furry coward," muttered Skeletor.

At the entrance to the ship, Glimmer and Micah hugged each other fiercely. When they finally broke, the old king could see that his daughter was smiling through her tears.

"I'm so glad you're here," Glimmer sniffled. "So much happened. You wouldn't believe how scary things got! Oh, but I *totally* had everything under control."

“I know you did,” Micah smiled back. But he could tell there was more.

Glimmer’s face turned serious. “Dad,” she said shakily, tripping over her own words. “Listen. Entrapta’s theories about the other dimension were right. When we — I mean, didn’t know if…”

Bow stepped in. “Your highness, I think there’s someone you should see.” He beckoned gently. Still at a loss for words, Glimmer nodded and took her father’s hand, leading him inside the ship.

Micah’s heart was racing even before she rose from the chair and turned to face him. His breath caught when he saw the spreading wings, the shining light, the smiling face that he remembered so clearly.

Their eyes met. It was a miracle.

Just like on the island, a part of him couldn’t believe this was really happening. But it was.

They both reached out. They’d mourned each other once. Their hands met.

“Micah?” she asked, hardly believing it herself.

“Angie?”

Outside, both the princesses and their well-wishers had gathered around Adam, excitedly showing off the wonders of their planet. He gazed with delight at everything, marveling in the magical light of Etheria. His laugh brimmed with kindness.

Skeletor elbowed his way through the crowd. “I can’t let any of you delay me! Out of my way, now!” he jabbered. “This is no time for jokes!”

He made it to where Adora stood with her brother and glared. Adam turned in surprise, not sure what to expect. They stared at

each other.

Skeletor held his arms wide. “I’ve been waiting a long time for this moment!” he cried. “Take this, He-Man!”

Then he lunged forward, and wrapped Adam in an enormous hug.

“He-Man, I am your friend!”

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading! Your comments fill me with happiness.

The next chapter will be the last, I think. It'll be a big one.

I've been building to the reveal in this chapter for a little while! Entrapta finding a way to rescue Angella was the "juicy gossip" that Double Trouble noticed Hordak showing Adora back in "Romeo and Skeletor," and the purpose of the big mission being put together during the last few chapters. So many people commented that they enjoyed how this story wrapped up the show that I started thinking about what my ideal epilogue would be, and here we are! The Princess Alliance had quite the adventure on Eternia, but this is the part I wanted to write.

Next, you are all cordially invited to Princess Prom. See you soon!

Skeletor and the Princesses of Power

Chapter Summary

> Scorpia hosts her first All-Princess Ball, and everyone is invited.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Listen to Skeletor's Super Prom Playlist here!

A lot could change in ten years. A lot could stay the same.

Ten years ago Scorpia had been a loyal Fright Zone follower, fighting for the Horde and scheming to attack the All-Princess Ball from within. Now she ruled the whole kingdom (they called it the Delight Zone these days) and with the decennial celebration approaching again it had been decided by unanimous agreement of the Princess Alliance that Scorpia should be the one to host.

An honor, in theory.

But Scorpia still worried, and wondered, and wanted desperately to do the right thing, even when she wasn't sure what that was. Fortunately, she could always count on her friends.

"For crying out loud, just do it however you want," Catra frowned through the viewscreen. "What are they gonna do, *un-princess* you?"

"There's actually very little consistency in these social experiments," Entrapta agreed, from another screen. "I've been doing some research and it would seem that nearly every previous 'Princess Prom'" — she curled her fingers in imitation of quotation marks — "has ended in some form of unmitigated disaster. Most

of the 'Ancient Rules of Hospitality' were added after the fact in an attempt to stop more wars being declared."

"Wow." Scorpia whistled. "That list is pretty long now. Does it work?"

Catra coughed. "Scorpia, we literally blew the last one up."

"Chaos always finds a way! *Aha-ha-ha!*" Entrapta laughed.

"Oh. That's less good." Scorpia touched a claw to her chin, pensively. She was sitting on her throne (it had been Hordak's, once upon a time, and her grandfather's before that) and surrounded on all sides by loyal, thriving subjects. Nevertheless, in that moment, she couldn't help feeling powerless and alone. No matter how many years went by, making choices as a leader didn't seem to get any less terrifying.

"I just don't want there to be any big unplanned problems," Scorpia sighed. "Some of the smaller kingdoms still don't completely trust us, you know? I need to make a good impression."

Entrapta looked thoughtful. "If you want, I could send Skeletor over to help," she offered. She leaned to the side, allowing a view of 'Skeletor,' a gangly reprogrammed Horde drone lurking in the lab behind her. He looked up and shook his fists.

"Myaah!" said Skeletor.

"I dunno," Scorpia worried. "Are you sure he won't be too… antisocial?"

"Everything I do is for the sake of evil," Skeletor pointed out.

Oh, don't worry!" Entrapta said. "We've been doing a lot of work on his people skills. Here, watch this!"

She cleared her throat and clapped her hair. "Skeletor! Initiate friendship mode two-zero-zero-two!"

Skeletor snapped to attention. "I *am* nice!" he announced with a smile.

"Very good!" Entrapta clapped again. "Now, activate decorating subroutine twenty-one!"

"What if we painted the ship a nice granite?" Skeletor wondered, glancing toward where Darla rested in the laboratory hangar.

Entrapta beamed. "See? He'll have your palace ready for the ball in no time!"

"Well… okay." Scorpia's face brightened. "I guess it couldn't hurt to have a little extra help."

"Great! I'll send him right over!" Entrapta giddily hung up her side of the call without waiting for a response.

"It's going to be *fine*," Catra cajoled as Scorpia nervously glanced back toward her. "No matter what happens."

Scorpia looked down. "I just want everything to be *perfect*."

"Remember, imperfections are beautiful!" Entrapta said, turning away from her darkened screen. "Ready to do your best, Skeletor?"

"Boobs!" Skeletor bellowed.

Two spindly robots poked their heads around the laboratory door. Skeletor was no longer the only refurbished Horde drone in the lab. In the years since Entrapta first made him, her work had continued apace. One of the new robots sported a massive metal mandible, and the other peered through a rotating visor affixed to its head.

"Trap Jaw! Tri-Klops!" Skeletor addressed them. "You know what you must do." He rubbed his hands together in anticipation. "Finally! Our chance to test the machine! *Nyeh-heh-heh*."

“Ha! Ha!” the others answered.

All three marched off down the hall, laughing evilly and nasally as they went.

“Be good!” Entrapta called after them. She returned to her keyboard and went back to work, humming a little tune as she typed.

A tall figure stepped softly out of the shadows. “Are you certain this is a wise plan, my dear?”

The years had changed Hordak. He wore his blue hair longer, his shoulders stooped a little lower, and he walked with a gleaming metal cane. He still had the same warm smile he always wore for Entrapta, however, and his voice was tender.

“Don’t worry! I’ve got it all under control!” Entrapta spun in her seat and faced her partner. “Scorpia is going to have the best party ever! Speaking of, how’s your research going? Did you look at those diagrams I gave you?”

“Ah, yes.” Hordak produced a sheaf of papers, covered in sprawling maps of footprints and arrows. One was labeled “She-Ra Slide,” another “The Batusi.”

“Is dancing *truly* necessary to enjoy such a function? Perhaps I could use this opportunity to practice the conversational arts instead.”

Entrapta smiled. She stood up, and then she rose up, letting her hair bring her eye-to-eye with Hordak. She rested her arms around his neck.

“You don’t have to dance if you don’t want to,” Entrapta whispered, with a coy tilt of her chin. “But it would be a shame to let you stay a wallflower after Adora spent all that time helping you pick out such a nice dress.”

Entrapta traced her fingers down Hordak's arms. He shivered under her touch. She held his hand and his hip. Purple locks pressed into his back. They spun, slowly. Back and forth.

"There, you see? You just need someone strong enough to support you."

Hordak only held her in return, following her lead. Entrapta hummed a waltz and they turned together, moving to their own music. Hordak let his cane hang lightly in his fingers. Entrapta was still on her hair, feet moving on an imaginary floor far above the ground as she kept her red eyes locked with Hordak's.

He twirled, and she caught him in a low dip. They kissed.

"Very well," Hordak conceded. "You have convinced me, my love. Again."

Entrapta rippled to the ground and scooted to another workstation, Hordak in tow. "Great! Now, I want you to look at these samples of thaumaturgic particles I suspended in bioelectrical dampening fields. At *first* I thought it wasn't having a physical effect, but *then* I realized…"

Hordak listened. And his heart danced as well.

Catra ended the call and groaned. "I just wish Scorpia would stop *worrying* so much."

"Can you blame her, though?" Adora looked up from the chair she was sitting sideways in. "Every kingdom on the planet is going to be watching her."

"Why'd you vote for her to do it, then?" Catra stood up and paced the room. These days she wore her hair in a voluminous ponytail, and it bobbed anxiously up and down as she moved.

"Well, I still want the rest of the world to realize how much she's done," Adora said. "The Delight Zone is one of the strongest

elemental kingdoms now, but nobody will treat them like that until they actually see it for themselves."

"That's a very noble idea, but are you sure it will work?"

"Oh, I *know* it will work!" Adora sprang to her feet. She was wearing that massive, guileless grin that always caught Catra off guard, and beckoned as she strutted backward out of the door.

Catra followed her, not even trying to hide how smitten she was. They chased each other down the glimmering hallways of Bright Moon Palace until Adora stopped in front of the most important room of all.

She pointed through the ajar double doors that led into the throne room. Court audiences had ended hours ago; now only warm peace filled the wide tiled floors. The Queen and King were there — Glimmer and Bow, looking overjoyed and radiant in the light — but they were not alone. Two other regal figures laughed with them, enjoying the simple pleasures of being a family.

King Micah, happily retired and as proud of his daughter as any parent could hope for. And Angella, the heavenly matriarch, no mere dream or illusion but really, truly, there.

Angella's wings were open, and shining. A portrait of a miracle.

"You helped make that happen," Adora whispered to her wife. Her expression radiated pride.

"So did you!" Catra deflected back. "And the other princesses. And *really* it was Entrapta and Hordak's science that…"

"It was a team effort," Adora admitted, shrugging. "The point is, you, me, everyone who used to be in the Horde? It may not be how Hordak originally meant it, but we really are doing good for this planet. Together."

She looked again at the royal family. "And the people here *do* see that. They just have to really *see* it first to get it. Does that make

sense?”

Catra could feel herself falling in love all over again. By now it was a familiar sensation. She smiled and put her hand into Adora’s.

“Believe it or not, I think it does.”

Scorpia pushed the silent screens away.

She knew, in her brain, that there was a lot she didn’t have to worry about. Most of the preparations for the ball were already finished, and she had plenty of help and support. Her feelings, however, were another matter entirely.

“Hey there, love bug. Your stinger looks a little droopy. Anything I can do to help?”

Scorpia turned gratefully at the sound of Perfuma’s voice. The flowery princess rounded the arm of the cushioned throne and leaned over to give Scorpia a tender kiss on the forehead.

Scorpia blushed. “Oh gosh, I don’t know. I’m scared I’ll mess something up on the big night and everyone will be mad and I don’t know how to make that feeling go away.”

“It’s important to acknowledge the feelings you do have,” Perfuma said. She gently reached for a bright patch of flowers growing from the side of Scorpia’s throne. It was far from the only plant in the Delight Zone; in fact, vines and moss and all manner of other green living things stretched across the floor, up the walls, and out the door, covering the entire kingdom. The explosive bloom had begun when She-Ra banished Horde Prime for good all those years ago. Perfuma and Scorpia’s ministrations had kept the new forest alive and healthy ever since. The people who lived there did so happily, in harmony with the world around them.

“And the best use of your energy is to focus on the things you can control,” Perfuma continued. She coaxed a few more flowers out from between the leaves. “You can’t control what people think of

you, but as the Revered Hostess you *can* revoke their invitations and curse their family name for a generation!"

"Wow, I guess. Isn't that kind of a lot?"

Perfuma laughed and tucked a lilac behind Scorpia's ear. "What I mean is, you've made a good place here. The people who live in this kingdom had their lives shattered when the war ended. You were the one who took responsibility and built something healthy for them. We even have some citizens coming *back* from the Crimson Waste! Anyone who can't see the significance of that needs to align their own auras before they go harshing anyone else's."

She waved at the moss-covered walls, and they burst into rainbow bloom.

"Of course, I'll do what I can to keep things colorful too," Perfuma said with a smile.

Scorpia sniffled, smiled back, and felt her worries, at least some of them, falling away like water off a beetle's back. Perfuma always knew just what to say.

They hugged. It was still Scorpia's favorite thing to do.

Seconds later, their embrace was interrupted by the ground exploding in a massive plume of dust and mortar. Both women yelped and ducked behind the throne. When the smoke cleared, Scorpia inched her way to the edge of the smoldering hole and looked down.

Skeletor was on the floor below. Trap Jaw and Tri-Klops were with him, clumsily clawing at the controls of an oversized ray cannon aimed upwards.

"Our trusty heat gun cuts through anything! Even your palace floor!" Skeletor boasted.

"Oh, it's the decorators," Scorpia said.

"*Serenity now*," squeaked Perfuma.

On the night of the All-Princess Ball (theme: Desert Oasis Delight), light as bright as shining stars burst from Horror Hall. Swarms of princesses and plus ones filed excitedly into the party, some already swaying to the music pulsing inside.

Skeletor was operating the weapons check, with his two henchbots backing him up. A small robotic dog (a present from Entrapta, whom Skeletor had named Relay) stood on the counter and tried to look menacing as guests surrendered their swords, battle axes, and freeze-rays.

"What shall we do to make life miserable today?" Skeletor mused. "I'm not taking any chances! You're not to do anything until I tell you, understand? If I can't control you, our combined powers will have to destroy you! Absolute power is within my grasp!"

"Okay," said the princess fidgeting at the desk alongside her date. "So can we, like, go in now?"

"Yes, yes. Get out of my sight, morons!" Skeletor muttered, waving them through. He shook his fists in the air and cackled. "*Absolute power!*"

He looked back toward Trap Jaw and Tri-Klops. "We'll soon find out who has the nerve for our line of work. Let our evil grow! Let it reach out!"

"Hey there, bonehead!"

Skeletor whipped around at the cheerful outcry. The next group to approach the entrance were the Best Friends Squad themselves: Adora, Catra, Glimmer, and Bow, all dressed in their finest.

And there was another.

Angella hadn't been the only long-lost relative the princesses found when they quested through the space between dimensions.

Standing with Adora was another living First One, her own twin brother Adam. Once, he and the tiny band of their people Adora herself was taken from as a baby had been lost to time and legend, fighting on a far-off planet called Eternia.

Now, he was here to enjoy dancing, snacks, and social opportunities in a comfortable controlled environment.

Skeletor scrambled to get in front of the approaching crew, addressing Adora first. "What! You? Along with those ragamuffins you brought with you?" He puffed out his chest. "Oh no you don't, She-Ra! No weapons at all!"

"I didn't bring any," Glimmer insisted, stepping forward. "Bow wouldn't let me."

"I think he means this," Adora answered. She held out her hand, and the Sword of Protection materialized out of thin air. "Sorry buddy, but I, uh, can't? Literally, I mean. Watch."

Adora set the sword down on Skeletor's counter and tried to walk away. Before she got more than twenty paces, the sword shimmered out of existence and reappeared in her hand. She looked back and shrugged apologetically.

"You think you're handy with that sword, eh?" Skeletor harrumphed. "Very well!" He waved them in.

"Smart choice," Catra smirked as she passed by.

"*Some* use their heads for something besides growing fur!" Skeletor snapped back, pouting. He allowed the royal couple through without incident, but held out his hand as Adam approached.

"Not so fast, He-Man!" Skeletor tapped his foot. "You flippant fool! I said, no weapons at all!"

"Weapons? I don't have any weapons." Adam shrugged innocently and turned around, showing there was nothing on his back but his

pink tuxedo.

“Hmph. Yes, you are all right,” Skeletor grumbled. “Now go away, I have things to do!”

As soon as they were inside, Adam winked and reached over his shoulder, tapping the hilt of his sword. “Ha! Fooled him again!”

“How do you keep *doing* that?” Adora hissed. “Does it turn invisible or something?”

Before Adam could answer, a blur of purple swooped down in front of their group, bouncing and babbling excitedly.

“Hi everyone! It’s great to see you! Isn’t this party amazing?” Entrapta exclaimed, tipping her tiny top hat. She pointed with her hair. “Tiny snacks are that way, and dancing is over there! I don’t know if the music is loud enough, though. Scorpia said it should be *really* loud, so I was just on my way to upgrade the sound system!” She waggled a hex driver. “Say hi to Hordak if you see him!”

She hopped away before anyone could answer, laughing and swinging across the rafters by her hair. The squad watched her go and then turned to look at the soiree awaiting them.

Horror Hall had never looked better. Bioluminescent plants hung from the walls and ceiling and electric lights of every color whizzed through the air. An insectoid band played on a raised stage, strumming guitars and belting ballads.

Frosta and Sweet Bee seemed to be comparing notes on potential dance partners. Mermista and Sea Hawk were either flirting, fighting, or both. The Star Siblings had occupied the buffet alongside the Star Sisters (they were, it turned out, descended from the same millennia-old spacefaring families) while Huntara flexed for a gaggle of fawning fans. Netossa and Spinnerella were getting their pictures painted with silly props and hats.

Minor royals flowed around the floor, giggling and gossiping.

"Can you believe it? The great Double Trouble is here! And they're with Lord Hordak's brother! *Well, one of them. The main one, who isn't him. What was his name again?"*

"Really? He must have brought them as a plus one. He is *the Princess of Dryl's brother-in-law, after all."*

"No, no, I *heard they were invited because they still own the Enchanted Grotto, and let the Revered Hostess sing there as Lynda D'Ream whenever she wants…"*

In front of the band, a small flock of clones danced together, moving their limbs in rhythmic imitation of robots. Some bee-people hovered by the punch bowl. And looking over it all was Scorpia, Perfuma on her arm, the arachnid princess filled to bursting with joy and looking like she had made it to heaven and learned how to fly.

Catra turned an ear to the music. "Um, did that singer just try to rhyme 'world' with 'heard'?"

Adora laughed, letting it all wash over her. There was happiness in her heart. She hummed in delight, already beginning to move her feet.

She had a good feeling about this.

Once Entrapta had finished making the adjustments she wanted (and recorded some observations on the prolonged effects of mingling, and ran a few chemical makeup tests on the tiny food) she went back to look for Hordak and her friends. She skipped and bounded, mostly paying little attention to the party guests around her until she turned a corner and came face to face with a grinning skull.

"Oh! Hello Skeletor. I thought you were working the door. What are you doing this far inside?" she asked, pleasantly.

Skeletor had a mischievous glint in his eyes. “If I am to know my enemies, fool, I must study them!” he confided, letting out an evil chuckle. “Soon… Soon!”

“Oh. Well, have fun with that!” Entrapta smiled and continued on her way.

She found Hordak at the far end of the ballroom, chatting amiably with Glimmer and Bow. The band was in full swing as she joined them, playing a song that had something to do with trying and praying and getting up a great big hill of hope, for a destination. Adora and Adam were on the dance floor, heads thrown back as they sang raucously along with the chorus.

“Hey, what’s going on?” Adora called out, waving to the four non-blondes.

She jogged over to them, giddy with excitement. “This is going so good! Isn’t this good? Are you guys having fun? I’m having fun!”

“This is the best prom ever!” Bow agreed, throwing his arm around a giggling Glimmer’s shoulder. “We haven’t danced this much in ages!”

Hordak looked proud of himself. “Indeed. Even I have partaken of this ‘dancing’ ritual. Entrapta and I shared a very pleasant rumba earlier in the evening.”

Adora looked unimpressed. “What? Only *one* dance? *Lame*. Come on, we gotta get you back out there!”

She held out an inviting hand. Hordak took a few seconds to realize what she meant, and then flattened his ears in surprise, casting a panicked look at Entrapta. To his dismay, she only gave him an encouraging grin and pushed him towards Adora. Catra appeared and seemed even *more* excited about the idea, flashing two exuberant thumbs-up.

Hordak knew that resistance was useless. “Very well,” he sighed, and followed his foundling to the dance floor.

Adora was careful of his cane and held his arm gently, with a steady hand. Hordak had a moment to reflect that the girl he'd found as a crying infant had grown into a fine gentlewoman and felt a small swell of pride. Then the music started again, and they were off.

The first few turns went smoothly enough. Hordak started to relax, enjoying the music and the movement. He didn't recognize this dance, but the steps seemed simple. Then there was a shift in tempo, and from the edge of his vision he noticed Entrapta repeatedly making an exaggerated elevating gesture with both hands.

"Okay, so this is the part where I lift you," Adora said, her tone entirely serious and matter-of-fact.

"Wait, *what* did you —" Hordak started, but it was too late. Adora wrapped her arms around his waist and hoisted him effortlessly into the air, as dozens of dancers around them did the same.

Hordak windmilled his arms to stay steady, secretly grateful for Adora's strength. He was vaguely aware of Entrapta applauding and of Catra doubled over in hysterics, but was far too focused on his own survival to worry about it very much. They turned once more, and then Hordak's feet mercifully touched the floor again.

"There was a time not so long ago when I was the most feared being on this planet," he growled to Adora, as the dance went on. "And you… *lifted* me."

Adora smiled fondly back. "Yeah, you did great! Isn't this fun?"

The music faded and they slowed to a stop. Dancers bowed to one another and the others gathered around again, laughing and clapping.

Hordak rubbed his chin thoughtfully. "Yes," he admitted, nodding slowly. "Much to my astonishment, I believe that I am, in fact, 'having fun.'" He curled his fingers in the same quotation gesture Entrapta had used earlier. "Thank you, Adora."

That was when disaster struck.

Before the music for the next dance could start, there was a sudden screech of feedback and the lights went dark. The crowd gasped. A familiar, reedy voice filled the room, cackling madly.

"*Myehehehehe*. Fools! Afraid of your own shadows! I'm afraid you've made a slip on this one. For your listening displeasure, a little concert!"

The lights came back up on the stage. In place of the band, Skeletor struck a powerful battle pose. Tri-Klops and Trap Jaw flanked him, glaring out at the frozen audience members.

Skeletor shook his fists. "Our alliance is over, fools! This is the way it had to end, with Skeletor triumphant at last!"

He held up an oversized remote control and pressed one of its many buttons. A giant trap door opened up under the dance floor, sending most of the assembled guests sliding into a wide pit below with loud cries of distress.

"Uh-oh," Scorpia said, from her vantage point on the throne. "I *knew* it didn't make any sense when he told me putting in that trap door really brought the room together."

"Oh, there are pillows at the bottom," someone's voice floated up from the pit.

"Ha! Got you at last, you troublesome tots!" Skeletor chortled. "Trap Jaw! Tri-Klops! Make certain something *unfortunate* happens to our guests!

"Not cool!" another one of the guests shouted from below. "Why are you even *doing* this?"

Skeletor looked down. "A stupid question!" he chuckled. "To answer your stupid question… I am completely and utterly evil! I'd sell out anyone! *Myaah-ha-ha!*"

However, not all of the partygoers had been caught in the trap. Entrapta had Hordak and the entire Best Friends Squad snagged safely in her hair, dangling from the ceiling like a many-limbed mobile.

Entrapta hurled Adora and Adam across the room. They landed on the stage in front of Skeletor and started toward him purposefully.

“You’re a loser, Skeletor,” Adam declared.

“You’ll see who the loser is!” Skeletor whinged back. He pushed another button on his remote.

Before they could take another step, metal bars burst from the floor and curled around the twins, enclosing them.

“Cage mines!” Adora gasped. “All right, that's it. Time for She-Ra!”

Adora’s sword flashed into her hand. A moment later, Adam had his.

“For the Honor of Grayskull!”

“By the Power of Grayskull!”

Nothing happened.

“Ha!” Skeletor laughed. “That cage is charged with magic! Our power-drain ray takes your power away! You’re powerless against me now!”

“That’s a thing?” Adora muttered, bemused.

Entrapta threw Bow next. “I’ll save you!” he boomed, as Glimmer teleported to his side. “With my mastery of tech, I’ll have you out of that cage in no time!”

“Silence, you soon-to-be prisoner!” Skeletor sneered. No sooner had he said this than another cage erupted out of the floor, trapping Bow and Glimmer.

“Ha! Your ugly friend sacrificed himself for nothing!” Skeletor gloated. “You’re not as smart or as strong as you think!”

“My husband is *very handsome!*” Glimmer shouted, battering ineffectively at the bars of their cage.

“I’m impressed by your courage!” Skeletor said, nodding in approval at the young queen’s show of incredible violence. “There must be some way I can take advantage of this situation. Perhaps we should let this walking lightbulb do our dirty work for us!”

Glimmer yelled something enraged and unintelligible.

Skeletor shook his head. “No, it is I who should rule! I’ve done more than you!” he concluded. He seized a microphone stand and shook it over his head. “I have the power! Me! King Skeletor!”

“Not so fast!”

As if on cue, a new spotlight sparked to life, illuminating the throne at the other end of the ballroom. Scorpia stood there, one claw thrust forward at the invaders as she strode down the steps. Electrical energy crackled around her form.

“You are being *very* rude!” Scorpia scolded. “I didn’t wanna have to do this, but as Hostess, in accordance with the rules set down over the centuries, I would like to ask you politely but firmly to leave.”

A bolt of red lightning arced from her claw and knocked Skeletor to the ground with a startled shriek. Perfuma, caught in another cage mine, clapped and cheered. Skeletor struggled to his feet, only to see Catra landing nimbly on his opposite side, cutting off escape. Entrapta, Hordak draped across her arms in a flowing princess carry, touched down behind her a moment later.

“Fools! Can your army of has-beens match my evil servants?” Skeletor bleated. “Robots, get them!”

Trap Jaw and Tri-Klops rushed in opposite directions to take on their new opponents. Trap Jaw attempted to tackle Catra, only for his arms to close on nothing as she leaped out of the way. Hordak stuck out a foot to trip the stumbling robot, and Entrapta ensnared him with her hair.

Trap Jaw howled in dismay, clanking his metal teeth helplessly.

“Sorry Trap Jaw, I must think of myself, not you!” Skeletor called. He fled the other way, pointing to Scorpia and barking an attack order to Tri-Klops.

The three-eyed robot seemed distracted, however. Instead of going to battle with Scorpia, he hesitated uncertainly, anxiously looking back and forth between his cohorts. Making a decision, he abandoned Skeletor and ran to help Trap Jaw, who was still being held helplessly in the air.

“Miserable wimp!” Skeletor groused, watching him go. “The both of you are fools! A fine pack of sniveling cowards you turned out to be.”

Skeletor faced Scorpia. “How really unpleasant it is to see you!”

“You’re mean,” Scorpia said simply. She flicked the cantankerous bot lightly with one claw-tip, and he went careening backwards in a shower of sparks.

He landed near Catra, who hefted a heavy dish from the buffet table. “Hope you like spoo, buddy!”

“Spoo? I *hate* spoo!” Skeletor wailed as the food hit him in the face. “I don’t even know what spoo is,” he moaned, wiping the slop away from his eyes.

Tri-Klops had long since been caught in Entrapta’s hair and hung helplessly next to Trap Jaw. The two robots reached for each

other in vain while Hordak tutted over them disapprovingly.

Skeletor cringed when Scorpia approached. “You’ve not heard the last of me!” he attempted, feebly. “Eek! No! Put me down! Down, you muscle-head!”

Scorpia paid Skeletor’s angry words no mind, as she picked him up and heaved him out the front door in one decisive swing. She dusted off her claws and a distant *thud* echoed from outside.

“Myaah,” a defeated voice muttered in the distance.

And that was that.

“Oh gosh,” Scorpia said when she turned back. “That got a little messy. Is everyone okay?”

The entire ballroom cheered.

Scorpia blushed, struck by the crowd’s approval. “Aw shucks. Well then, whaddya say we get you some ladders and go back to partying?”

The cheers grew louder.

The rest of the evening went as smooth as sandglass.

Adora waltzed with Catra. Scorpia and Perfuma orbited near them and the Delight Zone’s ruler leaned down to whisper excitedly.

“This is going even better than I hoped!” Scorpia exulted. “Everyone is saying we’re heroes! There are a dozen kingdoms asking for alliances already!”

Entrapta and Hordak danced close together, intertwined with one another and looking happily lost in their own little universe. When the music swelled, Entrapta used her hair to lift Hordak up above her head as he pointed his legs and stretched out his arms. They were clearly having the time of their lives.

Glimmer and Bow laughed by the punch bowl, trading inside jokes.

Adam was dancing with one of Bow's older brothers. When Adora looked across at him, he grinned goofily and gave a self-congratulatory thumbs-up. Adora returned it.

Somehow, Trap Jaw and Tri-Klops had found their way to the dance floor. They rotated like a sprocket in each other's arms, as the music implored them not to cry out loud.

Entrapta made a note on her datapad. "Well, that was unexpected. But I like the results!"

Scorpia took the stage to hoots and applause. She waved, smiling, and the crowd cheered louder. One of the musicians handed her their guitar, and she leaned in toward the microphone.

"Hello Etheria!"

The audience roared back.

Her claw crackling with energy, Scorpia strummed a powerful chord. So powerful, in fact, that the reverberating echo of it burst out of the speakers in an electric tidal wave that shook the walls. The room rumbled.

Entrapta punched the air. "Boom! Upgrades!"

The crowd went wild.

Later that night, somewhere in the Etherian wilds, the chime of a communicator pad rang out. Skeletor answered it with a laugh and a grin.

"Nice going!" he tittered. "Clever brain!"

"Thanks. You did great!" Entrapta answered. "It's like I always say, the best way to avoid an unplanned disaster is with a *planned*

disaster! Excellent work being evil, incidentally. You're a natural, for goodness sake!"

"You flatter me!" Skeletor said. "I never *ever* do anything for *goodness* sake!"

"Fair enough." On the other side of the screen, Entrapta spun idly in her chair. "Anyway, I think it's safe for you to come back to the lab now. You want me to come pick you up?"

"And accept a favor from you? I'd rather walk!"

"Are you sure?" Entrapta tilted her head. "I could get the Doom Balloon and meet you in… what's that noise?"

Skeletor was rustling a tree branch in front of the communicator's speaker. "Some sort of interference. There must be another magician nearby," he lied. "The fiend's power is too great! I bid you a fond farewell, forever!"

"What are you —" Entrapta started, but Skeletor had already switched off the screen.

"Now, with one magical gesture the spell will be complete!" Skeletor crowed. He hurled the datapad as far as he could into the distance.

At his feet, Relay the robotic dog barked cheerfully. Skeletor would return, eventually. Perhaps. He always did. But not yet. He rubbed his chin thoughtfully, contemplating his next scheme. It was time for him to start doing things independently.

Skeletor scanned the mountain range looming in the distance. It certainly seemed evil enough. "Hmm. Snake Mountain…" he mumbled quietly.

No, not mumbling. Rumbling.

Relay barked again, and Skeletor smiled fondly at the chrome canine, scooping him up in one arm. "We have a long walk ahead

of us.”

In Skeletor’s other hand was a long oilskin-wrapped package. He untied it now, revealing a tall walking staff topped with a yellowing ram’s skull. Relay nosed at it curiously.

“It was He-Man!” Skeletor giggled in explanation. “The fool traded it to me for Eternian silver! He doesn’t know its value. Sometimes my power amazes even me!”

Holding his havoc staff and his best friend, Skeletor ventured into the unknown. He felt like he could do anything.

“Let our power reach out once more!” Skeletor said. “Ha ha ha! Another time, He-Man and She-Ra! Another time! *Myaaaah!*”

Chapter End Notes

And they all lived happily ever after.

Thank you from the bottom of my heart for reading! When I started writing this I genuinely thought the Skeletor joke wouldn't last me more than a couple of pages. I'm both surprised and delighted that it's grown so much!

As usual, all of Skeletor's lines are 100% genuine Skeletor quotes, albeit taken completely out of context and mixed together. Almost all are from Alan Oppenheimer's incomparable performance in the 80s cartoons, but in this chapter Brian Dobson's Skeletor from 2002 and Mark Hamill's Skeletor from 2021 get a line each as well!

Hordak's dance with Adora is based on a post by strawberryoverlord on tumblr.

Whether you're reading this just as I've posted it or whether you've stumbled across it years later, I will read every single comment you leave and they will all make me happier than you can possibly imagine.

Until next time, friends!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!